



## PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

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### OFFICIAL REPORT

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Correction of errors of substance may be made only on the floor of the House with the permission of the Speaker. However, correction of typographical or grammatical errors which Members suggest for the Bound Volumes which will be compiled at the end of the Meeting may be clearly marked in the Daily Report, and the copy containing the corrections submitted at the Editor's Office, Parliament House, not later than four clear days after the publication of the Daily Report.

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THE  
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC  
OF GHANA

SECOND MEETING, 2025

Wednesday, 18<sup>th</sup> June, 2025

*The House met at 2.39 p.m.*

[THE SECOND DEPUTY SPEAKER  
IN THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, let us skip item two, we do not have any message from the President, neither do we have communication from the Speaker. So let us turn to item numbered five — *Correction of Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND  
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, page 1...12.

Yes, Hon Member for South Dayi and Majority Chief Whip?

**Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor:** Mr Speaker, may I humbly take you back to page 10. The essence of your direction to the Ministers for Energy and Green Transition and the Interior as a consequence of Mr Ziedeng's Statement, was to get them to come to the House to as it were to brief us on whether or not they would have resources for support in terms of acquisition of life jackets and such

further measures, but with the way it has been captured, and I read:

“The Hon Second Deputy Speaker, taking cognisance of the statement and comments raised thereon by Hon Members, *directed* that the statement be brought to the attention of the Ministers for Energy and Green Transition, and the Interior to brief the House on the measures being put in place to prevent the recurrence of such disasters”

Mr Speaker, if it is captured this way, it is as if the Statement has been referred to them and they are already aware and something is being done, but currently, we are looking for some financial support to be able to acquire life jackets for distribution and other such measures. So, I believe that it should be captured as “to brief the House on measures to be taken to support such communities in such disasters”.

Mr Speaker, they cannot prevent disasters because disasters are bound to happen, but there should be preparations in place when it happens. Disasters cannot be prevented because they are *force majeure*. Therefore, it is what measures to put in place to support those communities so that when the disaster occurs, they can survive it. So that when I am in a life jacket and the boat sinks in a storm, I can stay afloat and be saved by a rescuer. I think that was the essence of what we were saying.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Prof Nyarko?

**Prof Nyarko:** Mr Speaker, with respect yesterday, that was what the Majority Chief Whip suggested but what is captured here in the *Votes and Proceedings* is what you said, and when the Ministers made the Statement, these matters would still arise. So, let us focus on what you said and not on what he wanted that was not captured.

Thank you.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Very well. I think—

**Mr Dafeamekpor:** Mr Speaker, I am guided, if these were what you said.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Hon Members let us move on to page 11...13

**Mr Dafeamekpor:** Mr Speaker, page 13, item numbered viii “Amegbletor” has been spelled “Amegletor” without the “b”.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Table Office should please take note and acknowledge the corrections.

Page 14...15

Yes, Hon Member for Afadjato?

**Mr Afriyie:** Thank you, Mr Speaker. The item numbered xxxiii, my good friend, Mr Edudzi Kudzo Tameklo is still in an acting position, and

2.49 p.m.

Since this is a house of record, the records must pay fidelity to the facts. Thank you.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** So, what are you saying?

**Mr Afriyie:** Mr Speaker, in effect, the “Ag.” is missing.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Table, please acknowledge the correction. Let us turn to page 16.

Yes, Prof Nyarko?

**Prof Kingsley Nyarko:** Mr Speaker, on page 16, the item numbered 3(xlvii), reads:

“Mr Ralph Osei-Boafo, Administrator, Energy Sector Levies Accounts”. And beneath that, we have “Public Limited Company”. So, I am not sure why we have “Public Limited Company” there.

So, the Table Office can check and do the needful if it is not properly captured. Thank you.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you. Table, take note of that.

Let us turn to page 17—20

Yes, Prof Nyarko?

**Prof Nyarko:** Mr Speaker, with respect, on page 20, the item numbered 3(iii) is captured as “Mr Emmanuel

Ofori, Director, “Innovationss”. The word “innovations” is captured with double “s”. It should be one “s”, so one of the “s” should be deleted. Thank you.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you so much.

Hon Afriyie, I think that was the same — Very well.

So, Table, kindly take note.

Yes, Dr Anabah?

**Dr Thomas Winsum Anabah:** Mr Speaker, sorry, let me take you — I have noticed that my name is written among the list of absentees for yesterday, but I was here.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Dr Anabah, I personally saw you.

**Dr Anabah:** Thank you.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** But the fact of the matter is that, you probably did not register your name.

**Dr Anabah:** I registered and signed.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Are you sure?

**Dr Anabah:** Mr Speaker, I am sure.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** All right.

**Dr Anabah:** Thank you.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Table, kindly check if he signed, then please effect the corrections.

Page 21—

Yes, Dr Kabiru Tiah Mahama?

**Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama:** Mr Chairman —

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** I am not Mr Chairman.

**Dr Mahama:** Mr Speaker — *[Laughter]* — I see on page 21, the item numbered 3 (xiv) captured as Dr Tanko Rashid-Computer.

I am sure this House is aware, and rightfully so, communication has been issued by Ghana Tertiary Education Commission (GTEC) to the effect that the title “Dr” attached to this name is problematic. And that also brings to the fore more issues regarding other communications that are directed at other Members of Parliament whose names still have those designations.

Mr Speaker, I think that, as a House, our records should not be seen to be contradicting with what state institutions are saying about certain titles acquired by certain members. And I am just seeking guidance of Mr Speaker, to see whether it is proper that we do not fall into the trap of addressing people with titles that they have not so earned, in line with the communication of GTEC. Mr Speaker, I ask for your direction and guidance regarding the item numbered 3(xiv). Thank you.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Very well.

Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

**Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor:** Mr Speaker, I am struggling to appreciate what Hon Kabiru is raising. As a matter of record, the Hon Member provided her title and name to this House. Some statement has been issued by a state institution without recourse to her. As the Whip, I engaged her when this matter came up.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Engaged who?

**Mr Dafeamekpor:** Yes, I engaged her.

[Pause]

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** The Hon Member is talking about the item numbered 3(xiv), “Dr Tanko Rashid-Computer”.

**Dr Mahama:** Mr Speaker, the Leader seems to be apprehensive. There is a day we would deal with that but today, we are dealing with the name in the item numbered 3(xiv).

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Hon Kabiru, I believe the person actually attended the meeting and put his name as such. As it stands now, this House is unable to actually affirm the situation. So let it stand as it is and as we move on, we would see how best to address it. Because I believe he appeared at the meeting and put the name as it has been put here. So, it is good that you have

raised this issue. We will look at it appropriately.

Page 22—

Yes, Prof Nyarko?

**Prof Nyarko:** Mr Speaker, on page 22, a very minor observation. The item numbered 3(xvi) is captured as “Ms Francisca Adjei, Director, Corporate...”. I am suggesting that we make it “Corporate Affairs” because she is the Corporate Affairs Manageress at Ghana Investment Fund for Electronic Communications (GIFEC).

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Table, take note of it and acknowledge the corrections.

**Prof Nyarko:** Mr Speaker, the Hon Member for Afadjato South raised an issue regarding the proper designation of an appointee. He was sure that my very good Friend, Edudzi Tameklo, is in an acting position. There are some also who are acting, but it is not well captured here. They are captured as if they have been interviewed and confirmed to be in a substantive position. So, we need to check all these things to be sure. Thank you.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Table, consequential effect, so let us look at all those who are in acting position and address it accordingly.

Page 24—25.

Yes, Hon Member for Afadjato South?

**Mr Afriyie:** Mr Speaker, thank you once again.

On page 25, item 1, first paragraph, the very last line. I think the word “and” should be deleted.

Mr Speaker, if you may, kindly permit me to read:

“The Committee met on Monday, 9<sup>th</sup> June, 2025 at 9:35 a.m. continued discussions with officials from the Ministry of Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations and its agencies and on their 2025 programme of activities.”

So, I wish that the “and” after the word “agencies” should be deleted. Thank you.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Table, take note of it.

Yes, Prof Nyarko?

**Prof Nyarko:** Mr Speaker, on that same item opening, what he said is correct. But on the first line which reads:

“The Committee met on Monday, 9<sup>th</sup> June, 2025 at 9:35 a.m. continued...”

Since there is no comma before the word “continued”, the preposition “and” should be captured there. Thank you.

2.59 p.m.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Very well. This is grammar, right?

Hon Members, page 26...27.

Hon Members, in the absence of any further corrections, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Tuesday 17<sup>th</sup> June, 2025, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Hon Members, I have in my hands the *Official Report* of 10<sup>th</sup> June, 2025.

Yes, Hon Member for Afadjato?

**Mr Afriyie:** Mr Speaker, permit me to take you to column 7, paragraph 2, line 11 to 14; I think when Speaker was delivering his message, he got to a point where he had to tell the Minority Leader and his Side to listen to him, and I think that that should be part of the official record over here, so, Mr Speaker, if you permit me, I will read and then seek your judgement.

“The prohibition against holding an Office of Profit or emolument applies broadly. It covers any position, appointment or role that confers financial benefit or material advantage on a Member of Parliament, Minister or Deputy Minister, whether in the public or private sector and whether held directly or through an intermediary. This includes but not limited to the following—Minority Leader, it is either you listen to me or you go with your group and whisper outside. When you finish, you come back”.

Mr Speaker, my point is that I think that that was just a comment Speaker made, which was not part of the official

communication and, once we have the opportunity, we should correct it.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** You are saying he just passed—

**Mr Afriyie:** Yes, I am of the view that—

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** This is the *Official Report*; whatever transpired here is captured. So, even what we are saying will be captured. Are you clear with it?

Hon Minister for Environment, Science and Technology?

**Dr Muhammed Murtala Ibrahim:** Mr Speaker, this is not to drag issues, but I think that Parliament is evolving. Our democracy is dynamic; so must Parliament be dynamic. I think that the Hon Member, perhaps, is seeking for Parliament to reconsider what is captured in the *Hansard* because there are many times that issues that may not be necessary, frankly speaking, and they are captured. Maybe, perhaps, going forward and taking into consideration the evolving nature of democracy in our Parliament, we ought to be looking at things like that to see if we do not necessarily need to capture everything in the *Hansard*.

Sometimes we are seeking information from the Office of Chamber Reporting, and then when you get the information to read, there are a lot of things you may not consider necessary. I experienced that for a research work I was doing, and I sought information from the Office of

Chamber Reporting, and there are a lot of things that, in the Ghanaian parlance, one can describe as *non fa*. So, I think that we need to be looking at the need to change those things. Because other parliaments have actually done that and taken into consideration the evolving nature of our democracy. Perhaps, it is just a suggestion from my Hon Colleague if we can take a second look at some of these things.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Well, what I know all over the world is that when you talk about official parliamentary records, it is verbatim; whatever is said here—Like what we are saying, it will be captured; it will be recorded, and that is what would be transmitted by way of *Official Report*. So, probably, if you are suggesting something, we will look at it. But I do not think it is something new. You have been here for some time, and you know how the *Official Report* is captured. Is that all?

[No correction was made to the *Official Report of Tuesday, 10<sup>th</sup> June, 2025*]

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, before we move to the next item on the Order Paper, indulge me to acknowledge our children at the Public Gallery who are here to witness what is going on. So, we have three schools.

The first school is Saint Anthony of Padua Catholic JHS. They are being led by Sonia Salbre — I do not know



whether I pronounced the name well — who is a teacher, and the school is located at Kwesimintsim Constituency in Takoradi. They are 67 in number.

*[Students from Saint Anthony of Padua Catholic JHS were acknowledged]*

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, those are your children.

**Mr Philip Fiifi Buckman:** Yes.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** You should take care of them.

**Mr Buckman:** Yes, Mr Speaker, I have already taken care of them. I have done the needful. In fact, my Leader assisted me to do the needful.

Mr Speaker, in fact, this school was once the best national award-winning school. They are the only public JHS which used urine to come out with electric energy. *[Hear! Hear!]*

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much.

**Mr Buckman:** Mr Speaker, yes, it is Saint Anthony of Padua. So, maybe, they will help us in solving our *dumsor* sometimes—*[Laughter]*

**Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, the Member of Parliament for Kwesimintsim has made a very profound disclosure on the exploits by the school. He said urine, but I would want him to clarify, whether it is a human urine or—*[Laughter]*—Mr Speaker, is it that of a human or some

other living animals? Then also, he said that, perhaps, there should be investment there to solve the *dumsor* problem. These are his words, not mine—*[Interruption]*—He said that; perhaps, these are his words, “In the future, it should be used to solve *dumsor*.” So, he acknowledges future *dumsor*—*[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, he should provide clarity as to the type of urine he is referring to. Is it urine from the student or some—*[Laughter]*

**Ms Cudjoe — rose —**

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Comfort Doyoe, what is it?

**Ms Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe:** Mr Speaker, I can see the students are here, and the teacher who led them is here. So, we can engage them after the Sitting if the Minority Leader wants, so that they show us which urine they were using for electricity—*[Laughter]*

3.09 p.m.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Hon Members, the second school is Anbell School Limited. They are led by Yvonne Tawiah, who is the accounts officer, and the school is located at Anyaa Sowutuom. Do we have the Member here? Very well. They are also 68 in number.

*[Pupils of Anbell School Limited were acknowledged]*

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** And the last school is Novous Golden

Heritage School. They are led by Sherif Mohammed, who is a teacher, and the school is located at Kpone Katamanso. Do we have the Member here? Very well. So, our children, I hope you are here to observe what your parents and your representatives are doing here. Please, it is not just an observance; take a cue from it, go and study hard, so that tomorrow, if we are not here, you also come and take over from us. You are most welcome, and we wish you well.

*[Pupils of Novous Golden Heritage School were acknowledged]*

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, we will move to the item numbered 6— Urgent Questions.

Yes, Majority Leader?

**Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga):** Mr Speaker, the House has requested a number of Ministers to come and brief us on certain very important matters. They include the issue of flooding with the onset of rains, and also some concern about the situation of Ghanaians in the United States of America (USA) given what is happening in relation to the repatriation of people who are not nationals of USA.

Mr Speaker, three Ministers are here, ready as usual, to brief the House. Then we have about six Ministers ready to answer Questions and eight Ministers ready to observe. Mr Speaker, there are so many Ministers that Members cannot finish asking Questions, and whatever Members want to be briefed on today,

from archaeology to zoology, they will get it.

Unfortunately, I do not see people on the other Side ready for the briefing. Where are they? One, two—Mr Speaker, on a day when I have assembled not less than eight Ministers—

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Majority Leader, do not invite us to that angle.

**Mr Ayariga:** All right, Mr Speaker; mine is a simple and humble plea. It is a humble plea for you to vary the Order of Business, so that the Ministers can brief the House.

We will start with the Minister for the Interior and the Minister for Works and Housing if you will so kindly vary the order of Business for us.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Yes?

**First Deputy Minority Whip (Alhaji Habib Iddrisu):** Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader and Leader of the House has not been able to tell us which rule he relied on in terms of varying the order of Business, especially when the Minister for the Interior, who is a master of procedure and rule, is here.

Mr Speaker, as the Majority Leader said, even the Minister for Foreign Affairs is here. I expected the Minister for Foreign Affairs to either be in Israel or Iran, because the last crisis that happened in Ukraine when he was a Ranking Member of the Committee on Foreign Affairs and Regional

Integration, he was there and he took pictures with the students. Today, there is the same crisis in Israel and Iran; what is he doing in Parliament here?

Mr Speaker, if we have to take the Statement, we will agree with him on one condition, that the Statement of Hon Dapaah has been long overdue. Even yesterday, you said we would take it, and you have said so today. Let us take his Statement and come to that of the Minister for the Interior, then we can be able to proceed on that. But we need the Minister for Foreign Affairs in Israel or Iran; Ghanaians are there. We do not know their fate, whether they are alive or not. What is he doing in Ghana? He should go to Iran.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Majority Leader?

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, I am pleading with them to let us have the briefings from the Ministers. They have Cabinet meeting tomorrow, but I have all of them here to provide the briefings. In spite of the fact that there are voluminous Cabinet papers and memoranda for them to peruse before tomorrow, they are all seated here. So, let us take the briefings and the Questions from the Ministers, then we can do our usual Statements.

Mr Speaker, this is just so that he will know that Order 67(2) empowers you to vary the order of Business. It reads,

“The Order of Business set out in the Order Paper may, by leave of the Speaker, be varied at any sitting.”

So, Mr Speaker, it is clear that you can vary the order of Business—*[Interruption]*—No, he can refuse the application; there is no doubt about that. But the Speaker does not act based on the instigation of the Minority Leader. The Speaker will not be instigated by you.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Dapaah, yesterday, I made a solemn promise that today, we will take your Statement. So, even if we have to stay here until 10 p.m., I will take your Statement. So, you give me some small time to deal with the Ministers, then I will come back to you.

Yes, so we would start with Hon Minister for the Interior.

## STATEMENTS

### Recent Flooding Incidents Across the Country

**Minister for the Interior (Alhaji Mohammed-Mubarak Muntaka) (MP):** Mr Speaker, there have been reported cases of floods since the rains set in in May this year, leading to fatalities and rescues in some communities. The hydro-meteorological disasters such as floods, windstorms, dam spillage and tidal waves have become recurrent phenomena that happen every year across the country, causing loss of life, livelihood, property, and social distortion with high financial implications.

Mr Speaker, three types of floods occur in Ghana. Pluvial floods or flash floods occur mostly in urban settlements when the intensity of rainfall exceeds the

infiltration capacity. Then we have the fluvial floods or river floods which occur when high rainfall causes high water levels in the river and leads to overflow of its banks. Then the last one is the coastal flood which occurs along the 550-kilometre coastline of Ghana, induced by high tides and stormy seas.

Mr Speaker, the identified flood-prone areas in Ghana are settlements along the water bodies and urban areas such as Accra, Kumasi, Tema, Tamale, Cape Coast, and Sekondi Takoradi. The flood, in most of these areas, can be attributed to a poor drainage system and human activities.

Mr Speaker, climate change is one of the major causes of floods that has heightened disaster risks across the globe and an underlying trigger of hydro-meteorological disasters, including flooding. The change in weather patterns and the drastic rise in the volume of flood levels have revealed a wide range of weaknesses in the disaster preparedness and emergency response system in Ghana and exposed the vulnerability of the population living along the river basins, major drains and coastal lines.

3.19 p.m.

As part of measures to address the recent flooding incident, the National Disaster Management Organisation, (NADMO) has as of March 2025, activated the Flood Contingency Plan to put the country in readiness for the heavy rains forecasted by the Ghana Meteorological Agency. The contingency plans involve, one, the preparedness

phase where all the Disaster Management Committees at the national, regional, metropolitan, municipal, and district levels, together with the Disaster Volunteer Group, initiate the following activities:

- (a) Embark on massive dredging and desilting of water basins and drains in their communities;
- (b) Restoration of water basins and drains through excavation and demolition;
- (c) Identification of safe haven, evacuation routes, and reinforcement of search and rescue units;
- (d) Testing of equipment operational by the operation units;
- (e) Activation and strict monitoring of early warning systems;
- (f) Public sensitisation, capacity building for resilience;
- (g) Propositioning of resources.

Mr Speaker, the response phase is when the flooding has occurred and the operational unit, together with partner agencies, engaged in the disaster by:

- (a) Conducting search and rescue operations;
- (b) Cleaning of blocked waterways and drains;
- (c) Evacuation of victims to safe havens;

- (d) Provision of care and relief to victims;
- (e) Coordination of resources for impact relief;
- (f) Management of the safe haven until all victims are able to return to their homes.

Mr Speaker, the third phase is the recovery phase. This entails the restoration of services in the short term and resettlement, restoration of livelihood and the reconstruction of damaged infrastructure in the medium-term post-disaster period.

Mr Speaker, NADMO partner agencies such as the Ghana Armed Forces (GAF), the Ghana National Fire Service (GNFS), the Ghana Water Company Limited (GWCL), the Ghana Hydrological Authority (GHA), Ghana Police Service (GPS), National Ambulance, and the Ghana Meteorological Agency (GMA) to carry out its exercise. The Contingency Plan serves as a measure put in place by Government, spearheaded by NADMO, to prevent flooding and minimise its impact in the event that it occurs. It also saves lives and property as well as provides relief with focus on the vulnerable such as women, children, physically challenged, and the elderly.

Mr Speaker, the Ghana National Fire Service has also taken initiative to carry out public education on flood safety, flood risk and emergency contact on social media and through community outreach activities. The service has also

conducted flood risk assessment in all the 16 regions of Ghana National Fire Service's Regional Command. The assessment cited 86 fuel and gas stations nationwide identified as flood-prone. The risk assessment findings have been shared with NADMO for proactive measures.

Mr Speaker, despite the measures put in place to prevent or mitigate incidents of flooding nationwide, bureaucratic bottlenecks that delay funding for procurement and deployment of assets, limited financial resources that suffer implementation of contingency plans, poor road network and inaccessible disaster sites, inadequate skilled staff to ensure effective coordination, lack of tool and skilled labour to create a reliable and centralised database for credible information, communication network failure, and poor internet access during emergency, inadequate fire tender; the few are currently performing market patrol duties. And lastly, insufficient equipment like fair water pumps to pump out water from homes, hospitals, schools, among others during flooding, ladders, life jackets, ropes and lines, and harnesses to carry out 24-hour patrols in flood-prone areas.

Mr Speaker, the state of affairs in NADMO; the challenges are enormous and like we said, since March 2025, we have put in measures to make sure that we procure the necessary equipment and logistics to stuff the warehouses of NADMO so that we will be able to deal with these disasters when they occur. Unfortunately, because of challenges, we

are currently in talks with the Minister of Finance to release the needed funds to enable NADMO to effectively implement its contingency plan. Additionally, the Ministry is collaborating with development partners and private sector partners to help resource the relevant agencies. The Ghana National Fire Service Regional Commands have collaborated with MMDAs for monthly cleanup of drains and gutters in their respective locations.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, NADMO and all relevant agencies need to be urgently resourced to provide the needed services during these emergencies. Mr Speaker, thank you.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much. Hon Members, today we have a lot, so I would control the comments.

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, there are two Statements; the Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources is also here to make a Statement on the same matter. So, if he can make his, we can combine the two to comment on them.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Very well, so Hon Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources — Hon Minority Leader, we are talking about flood and the likes.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, you may hear me first.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** All right, let me hear you.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, the practice as I have come to know is that the Leader of Government business would reach out and signal how he intends to proceed.

Mr Speaker, I will rest my case.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Very well, well noted.

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, I thought early on, I had indicated that there was a joint Statement by both of them, because this was a call made by the Minority Chief Whip. For several days, he kept insisting that he wanted both Ministers to come and explain what they are doing in relation to the flooding. That is why we got the two of them.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** I think his concern is just reach out to him.

**Mr Ayariga:** I thought when I got up earlier, I indicated that they will jointly make a Statement on the flooding, so please —

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Hon Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources, you may take the podium.

### **Recent Flooding Incidents in Ghana and Measures to Prevent Future Occurrence**

**Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources (Mr Kenneth Gilbert Adjei):** Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity to address the august House on an issue of growing national

concern. The recent flooding incidents across multiple regions have once again highlighted our shared vulnerability to natural disasters, especially those aggravated by human-induced factors.

Mr Speaker, before proceeding, allow me to express on behalf of the Government and the Ministry, our solidarity with all persons who have been displaced, injured or have suffered damage to their properties. These are not mere statistics. There are fellow citizens whose lives and livelihoods have been disrupted. We stand with them in these difficult times and remain committed to supporting their recovery and building their resilience.

Mr Speaker, flooding remains one of the most persistent and destructive natural hazards confronting Ghana, often resulting in the loss of lives, displacement of families, destruction of infrastructure and disruption to the economy. Flooding in Ghana has been a cyclical phenomenon with a significant event recorded in urban and peri-urban areas, particularly in Accra, Kumasi, Sekondi-Takoradi, parts of the Northern Region, Volta Region, and Western Region. Since the 1960s, major floods have occurred, but the frequency and severity have increased, particularly since the early 2000s.

Mr Speaker, in response to these recurrent disasters, the Government instituted the National Flood Control Programme in 2009, aimed at reducing urban and peri-urban flood risk by expanding and upgrading drainage infrastructure, increasing the resilience

of communities and critical infrastructure to extreme weather events, preventing the recurrence of catastrophic floods through sustainable engineering and regulatory practices, enhancing disaster preparedness and early warning capabilities.

3.29 p.m.

The Ghana Hydrological Authority, NADMO and MMDAs have since worked together under this framework to manage flood risk. Despite these efforts, enforcement challenges, rapid urbanisation, encroachment on waterways, climate change-induced extreme weather patterns have continued to retard progress.

Mr Speaker, the 2025 rainy season has once again brought significant devastation. Recent flood events have affected multiple regions, including Greater Accra, that is New Legon, Ofankor, Ashiyie, Lakeside, Community 25, Teshie, Pantang, some parts of Kasoa, among others. In Ashanti region also, Aboabo, Pelele, Asawase, and Amakom, Airport Roundabout, Kwadaso-Ohwimase among others. Western region also, Dixcove, Kwesimintsim, Enchi, Kansawrodo and others. Northern region, Gumani, Tamale Metropolis, and others, and for the Volta region, Juapong, Sokode, Mepe, and others.

Mr Speaker, the floods were triggered by intense rainfall, in some cases, exceeding historical averages. Our technical assessments reveal these were compounded by human activities such as: unregulated construction of floodplains and buffer zones, choked and

under-seized drains, encroachment on wetlands and watercourses, poor waste disposal practices, road construction debris obstructing drainage channels, among others.

Mr Speaker, the rainfall event of 18th May 2025 particularly affected the Greater Accra Metropolitan area, severely impacting both low- and high-density areas. In response, my Ministry led a multi-agency reconnaissance mission to assess the map out high-risk flood corridors and propose engineering and policy interventions. Key sites assessed include Kokrobite Estuary, Ofankor Barrier, Haatso, Atomic Drain, Adentan-Ashiyie-Frafraha-New Legon corridor, and Sakumono, Densu, and Odaw catchments. The team discovered extensive illegal settlements, silted estuaries, blocked culverts, and unauthorised structures within waterways, undermining drainage systems and public safety.

Mr Speaker, to ensure a structured and a phased approach to tackling flood risk, the Ministry has adopted a comprehensive framework of immediate to medium and long-term solutions built on recent post-flood assessments, institutional experiences, and stakeholder inputs. These measures are intended to guide implementation of flood mitigation strategies and improve its effectiveness over time.

Mr Speaker, my Ministry's immediate priority is to address urgent flooding challenges, enhance existing drainage performance, as well as improve community readiness. These include: emergency desilting and drain cleaning

in hotspots, strict enforcement of development controls, including demolition of structures on waterways, public education campaigns on sanitation and flood risk, activation of the Flood Early Warning System (FEWS) in collaboration with GMet and NADMO. Medium-term strategies: in this phase, efforts will be focused on improving infrastructure resilience, institutional collaboration, and the integration of innovation, expansion and upgrading of drainage networks, deployment of real-time-based monitoring tools, construction of stormwater retention ponds, integrated floodplain management and green infrastructure, strengthened inter-agency collaboration for planning and emergency response.

Long-term strategies: the long-term vision aims at sustainable, climate-resilient flood management, which include overhaul of major urban drainage systems, periodic dredging of lagoons and coastal protection measures, construction of large-scale detention and retention basins, climate-resilient urban design codes, operationalisation of a National Hydrological Fund, to serve as a dedicated mechanism for hydrological infrastructure financing, use of AI-powered urban drainage planning tools, fully integrated into spatial development schemes.

Mr Speaker, additionally, we are collaborating with the private sector —

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:**  
Minister, hold on.



Hon Members, it appears we are not listening to the Minister. I can see all of you either engaged with somebody else or on your phone. You are not listening to him. Please, we brought him here to respond to certain needs of the country. So let us give him a hearing.

Minister, let us move on.

**Mr Adjei:** Mr Speaker, additionally, we are collaborating with the private sector to explore green and nature-based solutions which include: wetland protection and afforestation, rainwater harvesting and permeable pavements, pilot projects in selected river catchments to serve as demonstration models, development of nature-based solutions guidelines in collaboration with EPA and academia.

Mr Speaker, the ongoing World Bank-supported initiative, Greater Accra Resilient and Integrated Development (GARID) Project, is also aimed at mitigating flood risk and improving solid waste management in the Odaw Basin and surrounding communities. The GARID Project seeks to address causes of flooding in Greater Accra by: expanding and dredging primary drains such as the Odaw River and the Korle Lagoon, restructuring key bridges and culverts to improve hydraulic flow, enhancing waste collection services in low-income communities, supporting enforcement of planning and building regulations through digitised permitting systems, establishing a resettlement framework for people living in high-risk flood zones. GARID is a critical component of our medium to long-term

urban flood management strategy and serves as a model for expansion into other vulnerable regions.

Mr Speaker, to conclude, no amount of engineering will succeed without enforcement and civic responsibility. Developers must comply with planning laws; citizens must stop dumping waste into drains, and MMDAs must enforce building codes diligently. The Ministry is also collaborating with the Ministry of Education to integrate flood awareness into school curricula and promote youth-led sanitation campaigns. Public infrastructure must be matched with public discipline.

Mr Speaker, finally, the Ministry estimates that an investment of approximately US\$6 billion is needed to implement comprehensive flood control measures across the country. We will seek public-private partnerships, climate financing, and development partner support to realise this vision. We remain committed to building a Ghana that is flood-resilient, climate-smart and safe for all citizens. With the support of Parliament, stakeholders and the public, we can turn this crisis into an opportunity to build sustainable, inclusive infrastructure and protect our environment.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you, Hon Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resource.

Hon Members, we have listened to two Statements in connection with floods and related urgent issues. So, we

are going to invite Hon Members for comments, but like I said, we are going to manage because today, we have a lot to do.

Yes, NADMO Director General, the Hon Member for Ahafo Ano North?

**Mr Eric Nana Agyemang-Prempeh (NPP—Ahafo Ano North):** Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I am happy the two Ministers are here; both the Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resource and the Minister for the Interior.

Mr Speaker, first of all, I want to talk about the availability of funds to NADMO and other operational duties. Mr Speaker, this House passed a law of 3 per cent Common Fund to be given to NADMO for its operational duties. And with this, I am not talking for only one government, all successive governments, the availability of funds to National Disaster Management Organisation is a big problem. For the 3 per cent, sometimes in the whole year, NADMO will not receive a penny —

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, 3 per cent of what?

**Mr Agyemang-Prempeh:** The District Assemblies Common Fund allocation to National Disaster Management Organisation.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** So, that is the money that is paid to the District Assembly —

**Mr Agyemang-Prempeh:** Yes, 3 per cent of the total amount to the District Assembly Common Fund must go to NADMO. And sometimes, NADMO does not receive even a penny in the whole year. That is a sort of worry. When there is a disaster, NADMO must lead as a coordinating agency to coordinate all agencies to do search and rescue, need assessments, among other things. But in the process of doing need assessment and search and rescue, NADMO must move there with relief items, among other things. But here we are, I do not know whether the Minister is here to talk about it. You can go to NADMO now and it is possible there will be no relief items at the warehouse.

3.39 p.m.

Sometimes, all governments wait until there is a disaster before the Ministry of Finance will release money for NADMO to buy relief items. So, at the time they move in to do the search, rescue and needs assessment, what would they send to the people? That becomes a problem.

So, Mr Speaker, I think the Government should look at providing financial support to NADMO now. The rains are not done with us yet; we are in June, and in July, the rains will continue. Today, with the climate change adaptation, one cannot even determine whether it is only in June and July that we will experience rains. Like the Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources was saying, I think we must do a lot of dredging.

By August or September, the Société Nationale d'électricité du Burkina Faso (SONABEL) authority in Burkina Faso will spill the Bagre Dam and that comes with a lot of issues. Mr Speaker, areas like Yagaba Kubori, Kpasenkpe among other areas around the Pwalugu Dam will experience heavy flooding. Mr Speaker, by this time, we should have dredged there. So, Government should find money for the Ministry of Works, Housing and Water Resources to start dredging those places before the Bagre Dam spillage is also done.

Mr Speaker, the district assemblies, the development authorities and the physical development authorities at the various assemblies must crack the whip. It is time we empowered the district assemblies to make sure the approval processes of buildings in the various Metropolitan, Municipal and District Assemblies (MMDAs) are looked at. People are building everywhere, filling waterways, building fuel filling stations, and other things. That is part of the cause—[**An Hon Member:** When you were in office what did you do?] When I was in office, I did something. She should not say when I was in office—

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, address me, do not listen to them.

**Mr Agyemang-Prempeh:** Mr Speaker, we have one country called Ghana—When somebody was in office and he does something, when another person comes, he should continue.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, please, he has expertise and he is giving us critical information, so we need to listen. It is not a question of what he did when he was there. I do not think that is proper.

**Mr Agyemang-Prempeh:** Mr Speaker, we are talking about disaster management. When disaster strikes, it does not know anyone's political background, tribe or religion; it knows about each person as a Ghanaian. Disaster does not do politics or tribalism, therefore, let us look at solving our disaster problem with no political eyes. We should not say when we were in office, what did we do? We did something, but we must continue. That is what I am talking about. Nobody knows when disaster will befall a person.

We are talking about tidal waves and most affected areas are in the Volta Region which is a National Democratic Congress (NDC) stronghold. We all believe that the people of the Volta Region are also Ghanaians, therefore, we must find solutions to the tidal wave situation in the Volta Region. So, we should not bring politics into such debates.

Mr Speaker, NADMO needs funds. We must find money for NADMO to get relief items and a lot of equipment that they need to work. When the previous government assumed responsibility, NADMO had no vehicle that was less than 10 years, but the previous government bought 65 new pick-up trucks for NADMO. Today, there is a

new Government, let us continue to add up.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member?

**Mr Agyemang-Prempeh:** We did not complain but bought some, so they should continue.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member. You were doing very well. I was enjoying it, so I do not want you to mingle politics with this. This is a Statement you are commenting on, so just flow the way you were flowing.

**Mr Agyemang-Prempeh:** Thank you, Mr Speaker. Let us look at the problems we have as a country. We have a lot of problems when it comes to disaster management in this country. Successive governments have done a lot and we must continue it as a nation, that is what I stand for.

But now, the appeal I want to make is that the Minister for the Interior should lead the Director-General of NADMO to get funds from the Ministry of Finance to stock the warehouse of NADMO. This is so that when it is time for them to move in to do search and rescue, and needs assessment, they will not be found wanting. Also, I want to make an appeal to the Government to help the Ministry of Works, Housing and Water Resources to start desilting areas around Pwalugu Dam, the Yagaba-Kubori and Kpasenkpe. Because I know for a fact that this year, from August to September, the SONABEL authority of Burkina Faso

will spill the Bagre Dam and it will bring another problem. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much. Yes, Hon James Agalga?

**Mr James Agalga (NDC — Builsa North):** Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Speaker, I have listened to my good Friend, my Brother, and the former Director-General of the NADMO. He makes quite a number of interesting points. First of all, he says under his watch—

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, my plea is to address the issues that confront all of us, on which we brought the Ministers here. So, I do not think just responding to a Member who has made this comment is a—

**Mr Agalga:** Mr Speaker, I am guided, but the point he made flows directly from the Minister's Statement. So, I want to humbly ask for your leave to build on that point. The point he made was that throughout the period that the previous administration was in government, very old rickety vehicles were bequeathed to the administration under which he served as Director-General of NADMO. And this flows directly from the Minister's Statement. This is because listening to the Minister, he spoke about the lack of resources as one of the challenges which hampers the ability of NADMO to deliver effectively on its mandate.

Mr Speaker, what the former Director-General forgot to add is that it was under the watch of an NDC Government that the enabling Act, the Act NADMO derives its authority and powers from was re-enacted in 2016. Conscious efforts were made by this House, by the government of the day, which has come back to power, to establish a disaster management fund to ensure that the perennial challenges that NADMO is usually faced with are resolved once and for all.

Mr Speaker, I, as the Ranking Member at the time, summoned the Minister for the Interior here on numerous occasions and questioned him about why they were refusing and failing to implement the Disaster Management Fund. Finally, they listened to us and to good conscience and started with the implementation. For the first and only time, Mr Speaker, an amount of GH¢21 million was released into the NADMO Fund. Out of the GH¢21 million, Mr Speaker, my good Friend and Brother and NADMO were able to procure the vehicles he is now referring to.

So, but for the intervention of my Government, our Government, they would not have had money to procure those vehicles in the first place. So, my prayer is that—Now that we are back to square one, there is a new Government, there is an Act of Parliament which clearly creates a Disaster Management Fund—Let the Minister for Finance prioritise the work of NADMO and release moneys. These are statutory funds. Three per cent of the Common Fund is supposed to be paid into the

disaster management fund. It is a statutory issue.

3.49 p.m.

My prayer is that the new Minister for Finance would comply with the issue and ensure that the funds are released into the Disaster Management Fund, so that the issues to do with flooding, dredging, *et cetera*, can be dealt with once and for all.

I thank you for the opportunity, Mr Speaker.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, I will plead with you. This is a Statement which I should have even asked the Minister for Roads and Highways to also—Hon Governs, I should have even asked you to also make a Statement because this Statement we are talking about emanated from the Statement made by Hon Bede Ziedeng on account of school children who were crossing a river to Burkina Faso and got drowned, for which seven of them perished. It was during this comment that brought all these things. So, your invitation was also there to, at least, address that issue of the bridge of that big river.

Is it the White Volta or what river is it?

**Mr Kumah:** It is on the Black Volta at Dikpa between Bole and then stretching from Chache in Bole towards Lawra; it is the Black Volta that feeds the Bui Dam. Dikpa is there.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Thank you.

We would take Hon Amankwah-Manu.

**Mr Kofi Amankwah-Manu (NPP — Atwima Kwanwoma):** Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, and let me say a big thank you to the two Ministers for bringing an annual problem, once again, to the House.

Mr Speaker, we are never back to square one. Governance is continuous and we must continue as a nation—*[Hear! Hear!]*—Every year, we come to this House, and the sing-song is the same. Anytime the rains are in, we have a problem. Things are never right; for how long are we going to do this as a country? The Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources said something, and, for me, that was very instructive: that no matter the engineering and no matter what we do, if we, as citizens of this country, do not do that which is right, we will come back year in and year out and sing the same song. Our district assemblies must be up and working.

Mr Speaker, we all represent constituencies, and it is sad. Sometimes, you go and see people building on waterways, and we turn a blind eye to all these things. And when the rains are in, we come to complain. I believe the time has come that we take constructive plans and direction to address this flood problem. We cannot continue to be just talking. The Minister for Finance must do the needful. It was a surprise to me

when the Minister for the Interior said that they are talking to the Minister for Finance to release the needed funds to do that which we ought to have done yesterday.

Mr Speaker, we cannot be priding ourselves in the dollar depreciating or the cedi appreciating when our people are dying and properties are being destroyed. No, we need to save a situation, so the Minister for Finance must provide the needed money for the Minister for the Interior to procure that which we need to salvage the situation. We cannot continue to see people die and properties being destroyed; this is the time. We need the money to do that to save our people.

With these few words, Mr Speaker, I would like to say thank you.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much.

Let me acknowledge the Chairman of the Committee on Works and Housing.

**Chairman of the Committee on Works and Housing (Mr Vincent Oppong Asamoah):** Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, let me commend our Ministers for the Statement on the flood situation in Ghana. I would not want to discuss anything from the other Side. All that I want to do is to commend them. I think all the issues they have discussed are the germane issues that will be able to help us to solve the flooding situation in Ghana, especially, in Accra.

Mr Speaker, the Minister spoke about this Greater Accra Resilient and Integrated Development (GARID) Project. We all know that, in 2019, Government of Ghana secured US\$200 million to ensure that, at least, Accra could be a bit safe when it comes to the flooding situation. But the sad part of it is that you can go out there and see the real work that was done on the ground. I have said it that you weep for Mother Ghana. If we talk about value for money, we are supposed to build detention ponds, and the Minister said it. If one goes out there, not even one was built. The concrete drains that were supposed to have been constructed, what has been done?

From 2019 up to date, we are here talking about disaster and how to fund it. If we had invested this money very well, built the drains and the detention ponds, we would not be here talking about disaster relief. Now, even though we would have been talking about it, it would have reduced drastically because the money was not applied well. I remember the former President going to the Odaw River, talking about building some—There were nice pictures showed to Ghanaians. We were all impressed. The cameras were there, and he said that we were going to build tourist sites. At the end of it, go there, and you would see that the Odaw is still the same. It is even worse, so why do we have to politicise this? When it rains, we all suffer as a result of that.

For now, we need to look for money to construct the drains, the detention ponds, and we need to look into it.

Because there were some moneys that were advanced to contractors, and for over one year, US\$2 million has been given to a contractor, and he has not even moved to site—*[Interruption]*—Yes, they call it mobilisation. The contractors are unable to move to site because they have not paid compensations to people to move out of the place that they are. So how come they paid the money to them? And we are discussing this. We are not ashamed of what we did. We should be—As Ghanaians, if we should pay money, the money belongs to Ghana. Is that the way we have to use our money? US\$200 million—But go to the site, and we have absolutely nothing to show. We have the Minister here, and we are talking about disbursement because we have not spent money on NADMO. It is very important, but that is not the solution to the problem. Once we have money and want to solve problems, let us use the money so that Ghanaians will benefit from the money that we contracted.

Mr Speaker, let me commend the Minister, but we need to learn from what has happened previously that any money that we secure for Government for any project, we need to have value for money.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** I will take the last one from—

**Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor (NPP — Damongo):** Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, let me begin by thanking the Hon Ministers for the Interior and

Works, Housing and Water Resources for briefing this House. On a matter that, I am sure, is of grave importance as we have all acknowledged in the contributions. The perennial flooding of our cities and towns and the planning of our cities and towns generally—

Mr Speaker, I had the privilege to be in Government the last time, and I know that considerable work was done by the Akufo-Addo Administration—*[Interruption]*—In the efforts to deal with the perennial issue of flooding and, indeed, on planning generally.

Mr Speaker, my Brother, Hon Francis Asenso-Boakyie, for example, was the Minister for Works and Housing during the considerable period of the Akufo-Addo second term, and I know the enormous intervention and investment the Government put into building drains, dredging our drains and, generally, putting in measures to deal with the issue of disaster management and flooding.

Mr Speaker, I know, for example, that the Government of President Akufo-Addo set up a special task force which was to work to make Ghana adequately prepared should we even have an earthquake. Therefore, the Government was very sensitive and particular when it came to disaster management.

3.59 p.m.

Of course, Mr Speaker, as a country, the economy we have and the size of our purse will mean that there will be multiple competition for national

resources, and therefore, a Government will not be able to tackle all the various components of this long-standing and entrenched issue. But the point has to be made that considerable investment—A lot of work was done by the Akufo-Addo Administration when it comes to disaster management generally, town and country planning in particular, and investment in preventing flooding in our cities and towns across the country.

Mr Speaker, I listened to the Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources and the Minister for Interior. This Government has been in office for some six months, and the two Hon Ministers should be commended for updating this House and for bringing this matter up again. I was very attentive because I wanted to hear what the Government has done so far and what it intends to do in the short and medium to long term in building on what successive Governments have done in the past in respect of town and country planning, disaster management, and flooding.

Mr Speaker, we can give updates, make presentations, underscore the problem, blame previous Governments, throw figures about, and even misrepresent the facts, but the only way Accra will be safe from flooding, and the only way our country will be prepared for disaster management is for a government to get to work and take action. For the Government to have a plan, they must have done something so far in these six months and they must have a programme to deal with this matter. Mr Speaker, I am afraid; our Friends on the other Side, the talk is becoming too much.



Mr Speaker, just as I wind up, most of the contributions made have been useful, but I want to conclude by saying that we can only deal with flooding in our country and have a robust disaster management programme when we have a plan and when we get to work. The Akufo-Addo Government had a plan and contributed its bit. We would respectfully call on them to limit the talking and get to work. It is important they get to work.

Thank you, Mr Speaker. *[Hear! Hear!]*

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you.

All right, I will give you the last slot. Yes, Hon Member for Komenda/Edina/Eguafo/Abirem? We have got three here, so this is the third one and that is it.

**Mr Samuel Atta-Mills (NDC — Komenda/Edina/Eguafo/Abirem):** Mr Speaker, it is sad to hear Members from the other Side ask us what this Government is doing. They should go to NADMO and look for themselves; the building is falling apart. What did they do in the last eight years to, at least, even hold the building up? They should go there and it looks like the garage of somebody. Several broken down vehicles. What did they do? — *[Interruption]*—They should not let us treat—

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Samuel Atta-Mills?

**Mr Atta-Mills:** Yes, Mr Speaker.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Take your time—Hon Samuel Atta-Mills, you are not fighting with anybody; take your time.

**Mr Atta-Mills:** All right. Mr Speaker, I take a cue from that. Do not let us treat NADMO like we are treating a coffin-making company. One will need those coffins. When floods come, we will need NADMO. What have we prepared? What have we done? Let us work on it. Mr Speaker, it is sad when one goes out there. Are we ready for disaster management? Are we ready to save people? Do not let this be a talk shop. Let us not fold our arms and sleeves. Those who did not do it in the past—*[...Expunged by order of Mr Speaker]*—We are going to get it done—*[Uproar]*—

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Samuel Atta-Mills, please, withdraw that statement.

**Mr Atta-Mills:** I withdraw—*[Uproar]*

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Very well.

**Mr Atta-Mills:** So, Mr Speaker, thank you very much for this opportunity, but we need to work on it. We are going to work on it and we will make sure that it happens.

Thank you. *[Hear! Hear!]*

**Alhaji Habib Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, I understand that you said he should withdraw the word, which he has honourably done, but it should be

expunged from our record. Mr Speaker, kindly make that directive, and it is not these words that will make him a part of the remaining four Ministers. If he will be part of the four remaining Ministers, he will be part of it, but not with these words. He is my Friend; I want him to be part of the four remaining Ministers, but not with these kinds of words.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon First Deputy Minority Whip, I take a cue. Table, kindly expunge that statement from the records. He has withdrawn and I have asked that it be expunged, so please.

Hon Members, let us invite the Hon Minister for Foreign Affairs to also brief the House.

### **Comprehensive Update on Recent Developments of Ghana's Diplomatic Mission in Washington, D.C., USA**

**Minister for Foreign Affairs (Mr Samuel Okudzeto Ablakwa) (MP):** Mr Speaker, I have the honour to present to Parliament a comprehensive update on the recent developments regarding diplomatic Mission of Ghana in Washington, D.C., United States of America (USA).

As Members of this august House may be aware, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs took an extraordinary but necessary step on 26<sup>th</sup> May, 2025 to temporarily close the Mission in Washington, D.C. and recall staff to Accra following reports of grave legal infractions. This decision was made after thorough deliberations and prompted by

incriminating findings from a special audit team, which uncovered instances of fraud, conflict of interest, and corruption, particularly involving visa processing and the unauthorised activities of a third-party agent operating under the name, Ghana Travel Consultants (GTC). With the full support of His Excellency the President, this action marked the unwavering stance of our Government against corruption and our commitment to protect the integrity and the image of our foreign service.

Mr Speaker, the special audit team, which I set up, was made up of senior management of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. They uncovered a complex web of corruption that compromised the integrity and efficiency of the operations of the Embassy. Among the findings, are the unlawful activities and conflict of interest which involves one Mr Fred Kwarteng, who was formally employed on 11<sup>th</sup> August, 2017, according to our records at the Ministry, as an Information Technology Officer. Mr Kwarteng continued to work with the Mission with a renewal of annual temporary appointments. It has also emerged that Mr Fred Kwarteng was not qualified to be employed as a local staff as he does not possess the appropriate legal status to be employed in the USA.

4.09 p.m.

Mr Speaker, additionally, the investigations revealed that Mr Kwarteng is the owner and main operator of Ghana Travel Consultants. The company was later mysteriously contracted to provide exclusive courier handling for the

Mission, effective 1<sup>st</sup> January, 2023, by the former Ambassador, Her Excellency Hajia Alima Mahama.

The team discovered that this situation started as far back as 2019, therefore, the 2023 contract only sought to legitimise what was palpably wrong.

This dual role as IT contract staff and at the same time service provider where he illegally redirects applicants to his own company, GTC, created a criminally unacceptable situation where personal interest was clearly prioritised over official duties to the detriment of the mission's objectives and public trust.

Mr Speaker, investigations have revealed that on 19<sup>th</sup> November 2019, Mr Fred Kwarteng was issued a formal query when the then head of chancellery, H. E. Genevieve Akpalu, who is now the head of mission or the Ambassador at Ghana's Embassy in Tokyo, Japan — She first discovered this illegal link on the website. It is curious that not much appeared to have happened after that query. As shockingly, Mr Kwarteng became bolder with his unlawful activities, which continued after more than six years.

Mr Speaker, I have here with me a copy of the 2019 query and with your permission, I will read the query dated 19<sup>th</sup> November 2019, signed by Genevieve Akpalu, Minister Head of Chancellery, and it reads:

“Dear Sir, — Query, it has come to the notice of management of the embassy that in September 2019, you

modified the embassy's website in respect of visa, passport acquisition process without the necessary express approval. Will you explain why disciplinary action should not be taken against you for taking this unilateral important decision? Your response should reach the undersigned, not later than close of work on Wednesday, November 20, 2019”.

Mr Speaker, it remains a mystery how nothing happened after this query on 19<sup>th</sup> November, 2019.

Mr Speaker, the mission's engagement of GTC was characterised by an irregular procurement process and a blatant disregard for the provisions of the Public Procurement Act 2003 (Act 663) as amended by Act 914.

Furthermore, the contract between the mission and GTC was signed without a prior review and approval of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, raising questions about the legitimacy and transparency of the procurement process. The execution of this agreement was done without recourse to the head of chancellery, who is a principal accounting officer at each mission and whose duty it is to exercise proper control over the collection and disbursement of public funds and to ensure that proper system of accounts is kept per the Financial Administration Regulations 2004 (L.I 1802).

Mr Speaker, this lack of adherence to established protocols undermines the principles of accountability and good

governance that we strive to uphold in our diplomatic missions.

Nonetheless, the head of consular section, who has oversight responsibilities for all consular activities, including visa and passport processing, and the head of chancellery, cannot reasonably claim to have been unaware of the prevailing circumstances. Thus, their failure to perform in a proper manner, the duties imposed on them, contravened regulations, undermined efficient conduct, and brought the image and the good name of the Republic of Ghana into disrepute.

According to their own account, GTC had been depositing unspecified amounts into an unauthorised welfare account being operated by the mission, and these payments were not subject to audit until the payments were discontinued. This fact was known to the staff of the mission, and the said funds were used for unofficial activities by the mission on the blind side of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. The team discovered that GTC's website was directly linked to the mission's website for courier services, providing no alternative options to applicants. This unauthorised and illegal arrangement not only limited the choice of applicants, but also compelled the applicants to opt for the courier service provided by Mr Fred Kwarteng.

Mr Speaker, it is noteworthy that Fred Kwarteng's company operates from offices located about a 40-minute drive from the Embassy, raising concerns regarding the nature of this arrangement

and the extent of oversight exercised by the Embassy.

While the company operates a dedicated driver service that picks up and drops off passports between GTC and the Mission, applicants have the option to drop off and collect their documents in person at GTC. It remains a mystery how GTC was allowed to become an annex of our Embassy in Washington, DC.

Mr Speaker, in 2020, the Ministry entered an agreement with EMH Global, which was renewed in 2024, to standardise the websites of selected missions, including the Washington mission. However, these attempts were rebuffed by the Washington mission to avoid accountability and transparency. Even though Ghana paid for this contract to standardise all websites, only the Washington DC website was not standardised and reconfigured. Everything was done by staff of the mission to prevent EMH Global to carry out their legitimate contract which they had earned by the previous government.

Mr Speaker, to date, that synchronisation has not been done. Had it been done, the link used to redirect applicants to GTC's website for their illicit business would have been curtailed. It cannot, therefore, be justifiably claimed that this action was executed at the mission by a lone wolf at the lower echelons of the Mission's hierarchy.

Mr Speaker, you will agree with me that all service-related revenue must be managed in accordance with the Public

Financial Management Act 2016 (Act 921) and established ministry protocols under the Fees and Charges Miscellaneous Provisions Act 2022 (Act 1080) which was passed by this esteemed House.

Following the COVID-19 pandemic, the Mission adopted a full online mailing system for visa and passport dispatch. Again, this was managed by Mr Fred Kwarteng. Under this arrangement, applicants were offered delivery options via FedEx and USPS, for which they were charged a whopping US\$29.75 each.

Additionally, Mr Kwarteng's company, GTC, also introduced a new service where he invited applicants to come for assistance in completing visa and passport forms, where he charged them between US\$60 and US\$100 per applicant.

Mr Speaker, it will interest you to know that 99 per cent of all applicants utilised the services of GTC, meaning 99 per cent of all applicants paid an extra, unauthorised, illegal figure not approved by this House under our Fees and Charges law, between US\$29 and US\$100.

Mr Speaker, investigations conducted by the top management of our ministry revealed that GTC dispatched between 150 to 350 visas and passports daily. Therefore, on average, about 250 visas and passports were dispatched daily by GTC. Mr Speaker, this implies that yearly, GTC dispatched approximately 62,500 visas and passports. Mr Fred

Kwarteng was therefore raking an estimated US\$1,859,375 annually for courier services alone.

4.19 p.m.

Mr Speaker, you can comprehend the substantial sum he earns annually after adding fees for assisting applicants in completing their visa and passport forms, for which he charges between US\$60 and US\$100. By conservative analysis, Mr Fred Kwarteng made about US\$4.8 million annually from his unlawful enterprise. [**Some Hon Members:** Ei!] It is important to emphasise that there was no revenue-sharing arrangement with the Ministry. The Ministry of Foreign Affairs had no share. This US\$4.8 million was controlled totally by Mr Fred Kwarteng.

Mr Speaker, given that these are funds that were derived from unauthorised operations, it has become imperative to invite the Economic and Organised Crime Office (EOCO) and the Attorney-General to investigate, trace the proceeds, and prosecute Mr Fred Kwarteng and his collaborators, as instructed by President Mahama. This we have promptly done.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minister, just hold on. Is it a point of order?

**Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor:** Yes. Mr Speaker, let me apologise to the Minister for interrupting him. I have a copy of the Statement he distributed to us, and I have been following him. It seems the Minister is giving a different

Statement from what we have. In the Statement I have, Mr Speaker, on page four, he says the person rakes an estimated US\$1.8 million, but the Minister is saying US\$4 million. I want that to be reconciled. I have a different Statement.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Just about a year ago, you used to be here, and as a Minister—

**Mr S. A. Jinapor:** No, what I have is different. Mr Speaker, I just want to be sure we are on the same page with the Minister. The Statement that was distributed is different from the Statement the Minister is reading to us. That is my issue.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** All right.

**Mr Okudzeto:** Well, thank you very much, Mr Speaker. So, Mr Speaker, I encourage the respected Ranking Member of the Foreign Affairs Committee to pay attention to paragraph 17. It is the same Statement I am reading. So, the US\$1.8 million is for the courier service, and then the US\$4.8 million is where he adds the—It is all there. Paragraph 17. Let me read it again for them. He does not have paragraph 17? Let me read paragraph 17 for them.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Yes, go on.

**Mr Okudzeto:** I am reading paragraph 17 again for emphasis. This implies that this—All right.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minister, go ahead.

**Mr Okudzeto:** So, my Leader wants me to read from paragraph 16. Following the COVID-19 pandemic, the mission adopted a fully online mailing system for visa and passport dispatch, managed by Fred Kwarteng. Under this arrangement, applicants were offered delivery options via FedEx and USPS, for which they were charged a whopping US\$29.75. Additionally, GTC also aids applicants in completing visa and passport forms for a fee between US\$60 and US\$100 per applicant.

Mr Speaker, it will interest you to know that 99 per cent of all applicants utilised the services of GTC, meaning 99 per cent of all applicants paid the extra US\$29.75, which was not approved by this House. Investigations revealed that GTC dispatched between 150 to 350 visas and passports daily. Therefore, on average, about 250 visas and passports were dispatched daily by GTC.

Mr Speaker, this implies that yearly, GTC dispatched approximately 62,500 visas and passports. Mr Fred Kwarteng has therefore been raking in an estimated US\$1,859,375 annually for courier services alone. Therefore, Mr Speaker, you can comprehend—

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minister

**Alhaji Habib Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, I rise under Order 91(2a). It reads that a Minister of State may make a Statement

of Government Policy, and the Statement shall be limited to facts.

Mr Speaker, it shall be limited to facts which are necessary to be made known to the House. Based on the Statement he is making and the figures he is quoting, it is his assumption. They are not facts! [*Uproar*]

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Leader. No, how will you know that they are not facts?

**Alhaji Habib Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, the Minister is making his Statement based on assumptions, and assumptions are not facts. Yes, I have a copy of the Statement. He is assuming. These are not facts, Mr Speaker, the Minister must limit himself to facts, and what he is saying is not a fact.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Habib Iddrisu, you are a Leader, that is why I gave you that opportunity, but how can you say that the Minister's figures are not facts?

**Alhaji Habib Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, if you read the Minister's Statement, I have a copy of the Statement. I have it here. Mr Speaker, the Minister is not being factual because all the figures he is giving are based on assumptions.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Very well, resume your seat. Yes, Leader, let us hear you.

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, let us take the work we do here seriously. We are here as Members of Parliament to hold

the Executive accountable. We have a right to demand that members of the Executive, specifically Ministers, bring to this House to brief us on certain matters.

Mr Speaker, when this incident occurred, no less a person than the Minority Leader came to this House and demanded that we summon the Minister for Foreign Affairs to come and answer questions on why he had closed our mission down for two days. That is the Minority Leader himself.

The Minister is here, now let us educate ourselves on Parliamentary processes. When a Minister stands here and makes a Statement, and we feel strongly that he has misinformed the House, in some jurisdictions, in the United Kingdom, it is a basis for the Minister to be impeached by the House. So, when a Minister comes and is making a Statement, let us listen to him. When we finish and we have issues about certain factual statements made by the Minister, we can then take the Minister on. That is what we do.

3.29 p.m.

But when the Minister is making the Statement, people in the Frontench get up and they interrupt the Minister. This is not how we do it. If he makes a Statement and mentions a figure, we have the right, later on, to go and investigate and interrogate those figures. We can come back to this House and demand that the Minister be taken on because he has presented an inaccurate figure. The Minister has no

responsibility to give us copies of his Statement, but he has been magnanimous and shared copies with us. But the fact that we are holding copies does not mean that we should not listen to him. It is what he says here that is important, not what is in the Statement. He can actually amend what is in the Statement while speaking. If he notices something is inaccurate in the written Statement, he can, in delivery, amend it himself. What we will hold him by is what he says. So, I plead with Hon Members, if we want the Ministers to keep coming to answer our questions and make Statements when we summon them, let us accord them the opportunity to do so.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Leader, thank you. Hon Minister, please continue.

**Mr Ablakwa:** Mr Speaker, I am grateful to you. Let me state for the record that I am happy to make available the full Report of the audit team for Members to study and appreciate. Nothing being presented here is conjecture or is not the fact. I am presenting to this House incontrovertible, irrefutable facts and that has to be emphasised.

Mr Speaker, I take paragraph 17 again.

Therefore, we can comprehend that a substantial sum he earns annually after adding fees for assisting applicants in completing their visa and passport forms, which as I have emphasised was an illegal enterprise, not approved under our Fees and Charges Act. By analysis made by the audit team, the fact-finding team,

which is a team, as I have said earlier, made up of distinguished senior diplomats, management of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Mr Fred Kwarteng was making US\$4.8 million annually from his unlawful enterprise. It is important to emphasise that there was no share of this amount to the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. Given that these are funds that were derived from unauthorised operations, it has become imperative to invite the Economic and Organised Crime Office (EOCO), and the Attorney-General to investigate, trace the proceeds and prosecute Mr Fred Kwarteng and his collaborators, as instructed by the President.

Mr Speaker, I am glad to inform the House that this, the Ministry has promptly done. The investigation also revealed that the Auditor-General's Office had raised concerns about the Embassy's operations and financial management some two years ago. Specifically, the audit findings highlighted issues with procurement practises and financial accountability, which seem to have been ignored or inadequately addressed.

Mr Speaker, the investigations revealed that Mr Fred Kwarteng's company, GTC, was initially jointly owned with his ex-wife, which raises additional questions about the nature of their business relationship and potential conflict of interest. Admissions from Mr Fred Kwarteng himself, when he met the audit finding team, as well as current and former staff of the Embassy, confirm that he did not act alone in this matter. It appears that there may have been a



network of individuals involved in this web of corruption, which underscores the need for thorough investigation and accountability. We must contemplate the motivation behind the creation of a system that benefits a few individuals at the bottom of the food chain at our Diplomatic Mission.

Mr Speaker, in light of these findings, and in accordance with the reset agenda, my Ministry took the following decisive actions with the full blessing of President John Mahama: The immediate dismissal of Mr Fred Kwarteng. The recall of all staff of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs posted to the Washington Mission. The swift dissolution of the Embassy's IT department. The suspension of all the Embassy's locally recruited staff. The Auditor-General was promptly invited to conduct a forensic audit of all transactions. The temporary closure of the Embassy to finalise the restructuring and systems overhaul at the Embassy. We also issued a press release informing the public of the impending reopening of the Embassy three days after, that is on 29<sup>th</sup> May, 2025.

Mr Speaker, following the closure, I appointed the respected and distinguished Ambassador Mrs Jane Gasu Aheto, who was the Head of Legal Department until this recent appointment, as the Acting Head of Mission, and tasked her to lead a team of senior foreign service officers and personnel from the Research Department to Washington D.C. Their mission is as follows; restore integrity to the operations of the Embassy, overhaul the Mission's IT systems, implement internal

controls, address administrative gaps, and ensure a smooth and credible reopening of our diplomatic presence.

The team arrived in Washington between 31<sup>st</sup> May and 1<sup>st</sup> June, 2025. By that time, the Ministry's IT unit, in collaboration with interim staff from our New York Mission, had already laid the groundwork for the official reopening of the Mission on 29<sup>th</sup> May, 2025.

### **Key Findings and Challenges**

Mr Speaker, upon arrival, the team led by the Ambassador encountered a backlog of over 2,300 visa applications, and I am sure that Hon Members have seen a number of videos about frustrations being expressed by visa applicants at the Washington Embassy.

Mr Speaker, there was also no structured filing or tracking system in place, compounding the issue. An average of 350 new applications were being submitted daily. The situation was highly disorganised and required urgent intervention.

Mr Speaker, I arrived at the Mission on 1<sup>st</sup> June, 2025, to personally assess the situation on the ground. During my visit, I held meetings with both local and home-based staff, where I clearly conveyed the Government's position on the matter.

I underscored that Mr Fred Kwarteng, the principal suspect in this case, along with any accomplices, will be held fully accountable under the law. This includes cooperating with US authorities to freeze

their accounts linked to this criminal enterprise.

Mr Speaker, I issued a series of directives which are currently being enforced. This includes the establishment of an internal investigative committee to probe all locally recruited staff. EOCO has been formally notified to pursue Mr Fred Kwarteng, to trace the process of crime, and to have him brought to Ghana for prosecution. It also includes; a complete overhaul of the IT department and digital platforms; the streamlining of the Client Services Centre to enhance transparency; the implementation of a secure and trackable mailing system; the renovation of the Chancery Building to uplift its deteriorating image; and an introduction of a biometric clocking-in system to monitor staff attendance.

Mr Speaker, I am pleased to report that significant progress has been made between 27<sup>th</sup> May and 13<sup>th</sup> June, 2025. A total of 4,472 visas were processed and issued. 3,588 passports were dispatched. A further 3,729 visa applications were received. And all visa backlog cases from April and May 2025, have now been fully processed.

To manage the high volume of applications, the Mission's working hours have been extended from 8am to 8pm, with some officers working beyond 10 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I must commend the dedication and commitment of our Diplomats in rising to this challenge.

4.39 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the IT infrastructure of the Mission has been fully reconfigured to enhance security and service delivery. All the unauthorised access points have been removed, a live chat system has been introduced, and official email accounts have been updated to promote professionalism and responsiveness. In addition, three new phone lines have been added to reduce call congestion. Within a two-week period, 2,277 real-time online chats and 543 email enquiries were handled.

To further improve performance, the mission is also rolling out a mandatory training programme focused on professional client service and work ethics. Pursuant to these directives, the internal investigating committee has to date interviewed 25 locally recruited staff. A few individuals have since tendered their resignations. The remaining staff are scheduled to be interviewed within the week. A comprehensive report, including findings and recommendations, will be submitted upon the conclusion of the inquiry.

Mr Speaker, while the visa and passport issuance process has significantly improved, the primary challenge remains mailing delays largely due to logistical failures by the United States Postal Service, approximately 490 duly issued visa packages mailed on 6<sup>th</sup> and 9<sup>th</sup> June, 2025 were not properly scanned, leading to concerns among applicants. In response, we have directly engaged USPS to mitigate future disruptions. Measures implemented

include staggering mail dispatches to a maximum of 200 packages per day to enhance tracking and delivery efficiency.

Mr Speaker, may I stress that contrary to propaganda out there, no new recruitment has been carried out at our Washington, D.C. Mission. All the replacements are distinguished senior Foreign Service officers of many years of impeccable experience and integrity. Our decisive reset intervention, by not looking on as happened in the past, has sent a very clear message that the Mahama Administration will not be complicit in dubious schemes that border on corruption, conflict of interest, abuse of office, and cruel exploitation of clients of our Missions abroad—[*Hear! Hear!*]*—*Government's actions have projected a great and positive image of our beloved country.

In concluding, Mr Speaker, despite the serious nature of the infractions that led to the temporary closure of the Mission, I am pleased to report that the Washington, D.C. Mission has been fully reopened; operations are stabilising, and confidence in Ghana's diplomatic representation in the United States is being steadily restored.

Mr Speaker, as Minister, I remain resolutely committed to advancing the necessary institutional reforms, ensuring that justice is served in cases of corruption, conflict of interest, and abuse of office, upholding the highest standards of integrity and service delivery across all our Missions abroad. Mr Speaker, I will continue to keep this

House informed as both the investigations and reform processes progress.

I thank you very much for the opportunity.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much.

Hon Members, I will only take a comment each from each Side—

Hon Members, take the Order Paper and just go through. There are many Questions, and some of the Questions are even directed to the Minister in connection with this particular issue, so just bear with me; I will take just one comment from each Side. I do not know if Leadership will see sense with me that we ignore Leadership as well. So, I am taking one from each Side, and if you compromise with me, I will even skip Leadership.

So, I will take the Ranking Member and the Chairman of the Committee, then I give opportunity to Leadership.

But, please, bear in mind, now I have to be strict on the Orders. Order 93(5) provides that:

“A Member may comment on a Statement for a period not exceeding five minutes, and the comment shall not provoke debate.”

I am going to strictly adhere to that. I am doing this because of the many Businesses we have to conduct.

Yes, Majority Leader?

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, I agree with you that we need to manage our time very well. But this is a matter that engages significant national attention, and I recall that the Minority Leader, that very day, urgently, requested for an opportunity to make a Statement and demanded that the Minister for Foreign Affairs be here to answer Questions. A press conference was organised on the matter, and when we rescheduled the Minister for Foreign Affairs, he came under enormous attack.

Mr Speaker, today, such a comprehensive report, based on a total investigation of the situation, has been presented to the House. We cannot limit it to just one person on each Side. There is a significant interest on both sides of the House—[Hear! Hear!]  
—There is significant interest. So, I think we should allow three on each Side of the House.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Leader, respectfully, I will go with my ruling. Just look at the Urgent Questions filed by Samuel Abu Jinapor, and the Question is soliciting for almost the same information. Take a look at the Question (b), and it is almost the same line of Questions. So, I think all the information we need to provide to the nation can be solicited, if not through the Statement, through the Questions.

So, I want to just stick to what I have just said, which is one from each Side, and then I will give the opportunity to Leadership. Please, bear with me.

Yes, Hon Ranking Member?

**Ranking Member of the Committee on Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration (Mr Samuel Abu Jinapor):** Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Speaker, let me begin by thanking the Hon Minister for this very elaborate Statement given to the House and also to thank him and welcome his decision to share the report of the ministerial investigative committee to the House because, Mr Speaker, at the Committee level, we had requested for this report, and we are yet to have a look at the report.

Mr Speaker, let me very quickly make the point that we, from the Minority Side, are not against or opposed to any effort to establish accountability; we do not have any difficulty whatsoever and, indeed, Mr Speaker, we encourage the Minister to ensure that wherever there is rot or corruption, he should investigate, root it out, and bring the perpetrators to book.

Mr Speaker, a certain Mr Kwarteng is alleged to have been involved in a corrupt act, and that cannot be the burden of this Side of the House. I make this point because, in Government Machinery, even today, in this Government, we may have public and civil servant and officials, as part of the Government Machinery, conducting themselves in a manner which is inappropriate, and for those people, there should be investigations and if they are found out, they should be brought to book. So, we want to assure the Minister and the Ministry of Foreign Affairs that the Minority Caucus of the Committee on Foreign Affairs fully supports his effort.

4.49 p.m.

In any event, Mr Speaker, Mr Fred Kwarteng was recruited into the Washington Mission as far back as 2013, during the time of President Mahama. Mr Speaker, the contract for which the Minister is very unhappy about — The first time Mr Kwarteng was given a similar contract on a temporary basis was in the year 2015. I can furnish the Minister with evidence to support the assertions I am making.

Mr Speaker, what is the basis of this alleged corruption? I use the word “alleged” with great emphasis. The basis of it, to simplify it, is that the Mission in Washington is supposed to have gone into a certain arrangement with the company of Mr Kwarteng, because according to the Mission, there was some bureaucratic inertia in terms of transmitting visas and passport booklets to applicants.

Mr Speaker, the Minister himself is attempting an effort like that here in Ghana, where he is employing courier services for the transmission of passports to applicants. That is the basis for this alleged corruption, *simpliciter*. As we speak today, there is an Indian company called Premium which renders the same services the company of Mr Kwarteng is supposed to have been rendering to the Washington Mission, which has become the basis for this allegation of corruption. That company still renders the same service today.

So, Mr Speaker, what is the point? The point I seek to make is that the

foundation or basis on which the company of Mr Kwarteng was contracted in and by itself is not wrong. There is an Indian company that renders the same service today. The company of Mr Kwarteng was given a contract to render that same service on a temporary basis in 2015, and the Hon Minister, Mr Okudzeto Ablakwa, is making strenuous efforts in a welcomed manner, commendably, to render the same service to Ghanaians here in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, thirdly, the quantum of money or the funds that are supposed to have been accrued to the company of Mr Kwarteng, assuming without admitting, let me also put on record, are not public funds. Those are funds which were supposed to have been paid to the company of Mr Kwarteng on the basis of this Washington Mission’s contract with him; so, let us be clear. The US\$1.8 million and US\$4 million the Minister alluded to are not funds out of public exchequer. These are amounts that the Minister has put together and has estimated.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, there is a final point I need to make. So, the difficulty the Minority have had is the question on whether the allegation for which reason the Minister sets up the Committee of Enquiry, warranted the closure of the Washington Mission. Mr Speaker, let me refer you to the Vienna Convention on Diplomatic Relations 1961—

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member —

**Mr S. A. Jinapor:** Mr Speaker, it is important. As the Majority Leader rightly said, this is a matter which has generated a lot of domestic and international interest, and I am the Ranking Member to that Committee. With the greatest respect, Mr Speaker, may I refer you to the Vienna Convention on Diplomatic Relations 1961.

The Vienna Convention on Diplomatic Relations 1961 sets out copiously the steps that a country ought to take or adhere to in closing down a mission. The first step is that government decision must be at the highest level. There must be a notification to the host country and a coordination with the host country before the announcement and the reassignment of foreign service officers. Mr Speaker, these steps have to be adhered to.

And the point we made here, and if I may conclude on that —

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Your point is made.

**Mr S. A. Jinapor:** Mr Speaker, — is that the procedure which was adopted to close down the Washington Mission was one which is alien to public international law and is not consistent with the Vienna Convention on Diplomatic Relations 1961.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, thank you so much.

**Mr S. A. Jinapor:** In 48 hours, the Minister opened the Mission, and that

tells us that the decision was a rushed one. We welcome the probe and we do not have a difficulty with the probe, but we will always insist that we adhere to procedural propriety in terms of how we manage our foreign relations, foreign policy and the Missions of our country. That is the position of this Minority.

I thank you, Mr Speaker. [*Hear! Hear!*]

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, I decided not to pick because these interjections will always waste a lot of time. I beg of you, please.

**Alhaji Sayibu Suhuyini Alhassan (NDC — Tamale North):** Mr Speaker, this is a house of records. The Minister, in briefing this House, stated clearly that the gentleman was employed, according to the records of the Ministry, in 2017. The Hon Member, on the other hand, is telling this House that the gentleman was employed in 2013 without any evidence. Mr Speaker, this is a house of records and for us to make progress, it is important that these records are settled. It is as simple as that. He should just table it, so that, at least, we can verify. It adds to the records of this House.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Let me listen to the Hon Chairman of the Committee on Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration.

**Chairman of the Committee on Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration (Mr Alfred Okoe Vanderpuije):** Mr Speaker, having heard the report, as presented by the Minister for Foreign

Affairs, leading to the closure of the Washington Mission, one has no doubt than to conclude that the Minister did the right thing. The Minister saw a riot, rose to the occasion, took the necessary steps, and corrected the situation.

Mr Speaker, the country voted to reset this country. When the people spoke, they gave the mandate to His Excellency John Dramani Mahama and his appointees to correct corrupt practices, whether in this country or abroad, and that was what the Minister has done. The report of the Minister cannot be — No individual of this House should support this practise in any of our Missions.

Our students just left here, and if our children heard this report and we stand to defend it, please —*[Interruption]*— If we say we support the Minister, then let us support him all the way. *[Hear! Hear!]* We cannot say we support the Minister, turn around and question what the individual did. Please, that is not right. Ghanaians have voted to reset, and the Minister is resetting the Ministry. The Committee supports him in the action to reset. Yes. So, let us work together, because that is the mandate that Ghanaians have given us.

I stand to encourage the Minister that he should go all out. That is the mandate that has been given to us. We will work with the Ministry to ensure that Ghana sees better days in the future.

With these few words, I thank you, Mr Speaker. *[Hear! Hear!]*

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Let me now revert to the Leadership. Yes, Hon First Deputy Minority Whip?

**Alhaji Habib Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, with your leave, I yield to the Member of Parliament for Bosome Freho, Nana Asafo-Agyei Ayeh.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Nana Asafo-Agyei Ayeh, you have five minutes.

**Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh (NPP — Bosome Freho):** Mr Speaker, I want to also commend the Minister for availing himself to brief the House and to give us some information that is critical and crucial.

4.59 p.m.

Mr Speaker, just to also emphasise and make the point once again that this Side of the House, the Minority on the Committee, is not and will never be against the Minister's quest to probe or to ensure that the right thing is done. Mr Speaker, but diplomacy is tactfulness; diplomacy is backdoor talks. Diplomacy is consultation. Diplomacy is key and we must know that there are some things that should and must not be openly, overtly or covertly put out there.

Mr Speaker, I have the Minister's letter which designates a team of people who are supposed to take over at the Washington Embassy. Mr Speaker, Ambassador Mrs Jane Gasu-Aheto, Head of the Mission; Mr Bernard Quantson, Head of Consular; Mrs Bernice A. Podegbeke, Minister; Mrs Emanuella Karikari Agyemang.

Mr Speaker, there are records in the Ministry between 2011 and 2013 of one of the Members here who engaged in key issues that are fraudulent and corrupt. Mr Speaker, she was called back from the New York Mission. Mr Speaker, for emphasis, Mrs Jane Gasu-Aheto was at the New York Embassy. Mr Speaker, she was involved in corruption and she was called back to Ghana and out of settlement and arrangement, she was made to repay the moneys that was involved in this issue. [**Some Hon Members:** Eeeii!!] So, for the Minister to tell us that the Ministry is now taking, with all the descriptions and nomenclatures— Professional and exceptional Ambassadors or Ghanaians incorruptible to the Washington Embassy, we beg to differ. This matter, if I had not mentioned it here, the country did not even know about it. That is how diplomacy is treated. [*Hear! Hear!*] It does not mean that we should not apprehend or we should not deal with people who are involved in this issue.

Mr Speaker, the next thing to say, as it stands now, for the past two weeks that the Ministry announced that the Embassy will be reopened, the Embassy was reopened but was not functional. Mr Speaker, there was no delegation from Ghana that got to Washington. Rather, the Minister assigned some members from New York to go and take charge in the Washington Embassy and this has caused a lot of Ghanaians in Washington to go through devastation, challenges, and hardship to get visas and passports.

Mr Speaker, let it be on record that the decision to close the Embassy has

caused Ghana much more harm than good and we are becoming a joke in the eyes of the public. We must put that on record—

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Hon Majority Leader. [*Uproar*]

Hon Members, please, we have heard you. Let us listen to the Majority Leader. Yes, Leader.

**Mr Mahama Ayariga (NDC — Bawku Central):** Thank you very much. Mr Speaker, I think this House should thank the Minister for Foreign Affairs for coming to fully disclose to us exactly what happened in our Washington Mission. Mr Speaker, I think that clearly, the investigations reveal a number of infractions.

First and foremost, this is the only House that can decide on the fees and charges that any institution can levy on any person for a service rendered by the Republic of Ghana. This is the only House. And to the extent that this House did not approve of any charge for a service in the acquisition of a visa to enter Ghana, that is a clear infraction of the laws of Ghana. No matter how valuable the service, no matter how good intention it may have been, clearly there has been a violation of the laws of Ghana. And if for nothing, this House should be interested in that. How did it happen that civil servants on their own, without Parliamentary approval, sat down and created a business where services were rendered for the



acquisition of Ghanaian visas and payments? No matter what it is, there is a clear infraction of the law that this House should be interested in.

Secondly, Mr Speaker, we may dispute when Mr Kwarteng assumed office at the Embassy. But there is no dispute that he was the IT officer when he assumed office. Whichever date, but he assumed office as the IT officer of the Embassy. I am just giving you the benefit of doubt that as the IT officer, that he and, it is said, a spouse, own a company that was providing IT services to the same organisation. Mr Speaker, even if there is a similar contract in the UK for the acquisition of Ghanaian visas by an Indian company, let us not lose sight of the fact that for our IT officer at the Washington office to now set up a private company to render IT services, and the fees goes to him, no matter how good intentioned, that is a clear case of conflict of interest. Another clear instance of infraction of our laws. Mr Speaker, I think this House is the defender of the interests of the ordinary people who approach government for services. And I must commend the Minister for the effort that he took or made to stop this.

5.09 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the day that the Statement was made here, in this House, on my way home, a friend called me and told me that the figure we are even quoting is below what they were actually paying. He is ready to testify. What he told me was that it was deliberately made in such a way that you could not on your

own apply online for a visa. Deliberately. So even though you could apply online, it became impossible for anyone to apply online so that you would go and then seek the services of the company. This is where conflict of interest comes in. So, if the person in charge of our IT system at our Mission has a business of providing that service, why would it not be easy to make it impossible for people who can ordinarily apply online to apply so that they will seek the services of his company?

That is what conflict of interest is all about. So Mr Speaker, such a matter cannot come before this House and we will attempt to belittle it. We cannot attempt to belittle it. This is a very serious matter happening not here in Ghana but in Washington. Our institutions had degenerated to a point where we were exporting such practices to abroad. We had done it in Ghana, SML, whatever it was, so many concocted arrangements that today we have unending investigations. National Service Secretariat, everywhere you turn and we were not satisfied doing it domestically. We now decided that it is a commodity worth exporting to foreign countries and we were exporting to foreign countries. *[Laughter]*

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Leader, your time is almost up.

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, I think that Economic and Organised Crime Office (EOCO) must investigate the matter. We expect the Report of EOCO's investigation expedited and presented to this House by the Minister. This House is going to insist on swift and certain punishment for such violations of the flag and coat of arms of Ghana abroad in the United States. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, I heard somebody talk about hardship. Can he calculate the hardship of all those who had to go through this grueling treatment and had to cough out their money and you are talking about hardship. Whose hardship are we talking about here? Mr Speaker, I thank you very much. *[Hear! Hear!]*

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you.

Leadership, let me seek your pleasure. We have committed ourselves to take certain Statements. Can we continue with the Statements then we come to Questions? *[Interruption]*

I am pleading with you. So, I would take the Statement then I come to Questions. The Hon Ministers should bear with me, please.

There is a joint Statement on the cedi appreciation and Ghana's agricultural opportunity by the Minority Leader, Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin and Hon Elvis Osei Mensah Dapaah.

Yes, Hon Osei Mensah, you have the floor? But afterwards, I will come to the First Deputy Speaker's Statement.

### **Appreciation of the Cedi and Ghana's Agricultural Opportunity**

**Mr Elvis Osei Mensah Dapaah (NPP— Ahafo Ano South West):** Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity to make this Statement on the recent

appreciation of the Ghanaian cedi and the opportunities it presents for Ghana's agricultural transformation.

While the cedi's sharp recovery signals a welcome macroeconomic shift, it offers a unique window for structural investment in agriculture to address persistent food inflation, reduce input cost and boost productivity in a sector that remains central to livelihoods and national stability.

Mr Speaker, Ghana's public investment in agriculture has been persistently low and alarmingly, it has dropped even further under the current administration's 2025 budget. Only GH¢1.5 billion was allocated to the agriculture sector in 2025—a mere 0.5 per cent of the total GH¢290 billion budget. This is down from roughly 1.9 per cent of the budget in 2023 and 2024, which were already below the African Union 10 per cent Maputo/Malabo commitment.

Mr Speaker, per the Bank of Ghana's rates, the Ghanaian cedi has surged in 2025 from GH¢14.7 in the early part of the year to the GH¢10.2 in May against the U.S. dollar. The cause of this recovery follows a mix of both global and domestic factors; weakening US dollar on the world market, rising gold reserves at the Bank of Ghana (a result of the previous government's initiative) and perhaps some yet to be seen fiscal and monetary policies.

Food inflation in the country continues to remain high. Although inflation reduced to 18.4 per cent in May, food inflation is still hovering above 22

per cent. Such appreciation presents an opportunity for agriculture, which underpins economic stability and food security amid high food inflation.

Mr Speaker, a stronger cedi can make imported agro-inputs such as fertilisers, seeds, agrochemicals, and machinery more affordable, as Ghana imports the bulk of its agriculture inputs. For example, in 2024, Ghana imported GH¢38.6 billion worth of machinery and electrical equipment, representing 15.4 per cent of total imports. Also, bulldozers and herbicides anti-sprouting products and plant-growth regulators made the top 10 products that were imported in 2024, representing about 3.5 per cent of imports.

Mr Speaker, in the poultry value chain, one of the most persistent challenges is the cost of day-old chicks, most of which are imported due to weak local hatchery capacity. A stronger cedi makes these imports cheaper, potentially lowering production costs of local poultry farmers. Imported feed ingredients such as soyabean meal, maize additives, and premixes are also sensitive to exchange rate movements. If the cedi holds, domestic poultry producers may become more competitive, but also border protections and market linkages must be managed to prevent dumping of cheap frozen imports that undermine local input.

Mr Speaker, Ghana imports substantial quantities of rice, wheat, sugar, cooking oils, and flour. The appreciation of the currency reduces the cost of these imports, easing some

pressure on consumers, increasing disposable income for households, and potentially slowing food inflation. However, cheaper imports can also undercut local producers. For example, local rice poultry value chains have long struggled to compete with their imported alternatives due to scale and cost disadvantages. There must be a right balance: consumers want relief, but producers need protection.

Mr Speaker, the impact of cedi appreciation may also be felt in electricity pricing. Under Ghana's tariff adjustment mechanism, inflation and debt servicing influence utility prices. If the recent drop in the inflation and exchange rate pressures is sustained and if debt servicing costs are not rigidly passed on, utility tariff could ease or stabilise in the next quarter. Cheaper power could improve margins, support production schedules, and attract more investment into agro-industry.

Mr Speaker, while the cedi appreciation offers relief for input-dependent producers, it poses real risk for exporters, especially in agriculture. Over 70 per cent of Ghana's Non-Traditional Exports (NTEs) are agricultural products. The danger is that this appreciation, if not matched by a decline in the cost of doing business, from port charges to transport to financing, exporters could lose market share or see shrinking margins. This could discourage scale-up investments in high-value agro-export chains.

While the cedi appreciation offers a short-term cost advantage, the more

impactful way to tackle food inflation is by boosting domestic productivity through strategic investment.

5.19 p.m.

Mr Speaker, Ghana's agricultural sector is structurally weak due to its heavy dependence of imported food and input. In 2024, over half of Ghana's food supply was imported, amounting to around \$2 billion, exposing the country's external shocks and undermining domestic productivity. There is a need to create room to expand support for local fertiliser blending plants, invest in seed research and certified domestic seed systems, and reduce fiscal pressure from import-heavy subsidy programmes. Investing in local input ecosystems enhances long-term affordability and builds resilience against future exchange rate shocks.

Post-harvest losses in Ghana are persistently high, estimated at 20 per cent to 30 per cent for crops due to limited processing and cold chain capacity. Scaling agro-processing is crucial to absorb seasonal yield, stabilise prices, and create rural jobs. Investment priorities should include industrial agro-processing hubs near production zones, and small-scale equipment—

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, please, let us give him a hearing. I beg of you. Hon Member, continue.

**Mr Osei Mensah:** Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Many farmers lack access to reliable transport, cold storage, or structured aggregation centres. Investment in upgrading feeder systems will help reduce post-harvest losses. Improving logistics lowers food wastage, shortens mark cycle, and enhances national food distribution.

Mr Speaker, only 2 per cent of Ghana's arable land is irrigated, making crop production highly vulnerable to climate variability. With food inflation being a recurring concern, year-round production is critical. The cedi gain could be used to support expansion of smallholder irrigation schemes and rehabilitation of underperforming public irrigation projects. Irrigation links directly to increased crop intensity and supports off-season cultivation, especially for vegetables and high-value crops.

Low mechanisation is a constraint across much of Ghana's agriculture. Most smallholders rely on manual tools or animal traction, limiting land expansion and delaying time-sensitive operations like planting and harvesting. A stronger cedi makes it more affordable to import machinery, spare parts, and assembly kits. Strategic investment could include scaling mechanisation, service centres with public-private partnerships, supporting access to appropriate machinery for smallholder zones and incentivizing local assembly and repair workshops to reduce foreign dependency.

Agriculture contributes over 21 per cent of Gross Domestic Product (GDP), but its access to finance remains

disproportionately low. Data from Ghana Investment Promotion Centre (GIPC Quarterly Report) shows that Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) into agriculture averaged less than 2 per cent of total inflows between 2018 and 2024. For instance, only US\$1.5 million was recorded for the three projects in 2024, representing just 0.24 per cent of the year's total FDI of the US\$617.6 million.

This pattern is not limiting to foreign investment. Domestic credit to agriculture also remains marginal, with the sector receiving less than 5 per cent of the total bank lending in recent years. These figures point to the persistent and widening agriculture financing gap. The issue is not simply one of low funding, but also of high barriers to accessing what little credit is available. The recent 5<sup>th</sup> Anniversary Report of Ghana Incentive-based Risk-sharing System for Agricultural Lending (GIRSAL) reaffirmed what many actors in the sector already experience, that despite effort there, there is risk to agricultural lending. Systematic challenges remain. Due to perceived high risk, loans to actors in the agricultural value chain are often priced higher than in other sectors, while many smallholders, farmers and agribusiness lack the traditional collateral demands by the financial institutions.

Though the sector remains high impact, there is a large financing gap, without targeted credit schemes, blended finance and scale-friendly instruments, agriculture will continue to miss its potential, with favourable macro trends.

To conclude, Mr Speaker, I want to reiterate the fact that although the cedi

has appreciated recently, this surge has been driven by a combination of global and domestic factors. It offers a unique window for structural investment in agriculture to address persistent food inflation, reduce input costs, and boost productivity in a sector that remains central to livelihoods and national stability.

I thank you once again, Mr Speaker.

*[Hear! Hear!]*

*[Pause]*

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Minister for Environment, Science and Technology, what is it?

**Mr Ayariga** — *rose* —

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Leader?

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, we have a very loaded agenda —

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, please.

**Mr Ayariga:** We have a very loaded agenda today, except that we want to commend the first-timer for his courage and his bravery. Speaking in this House is not an easy thing, and there are many that come here and for several years, they still cannot find their voice on the floor of this House. So, I think that we commend him for the effort and encourage all other first-timers to put up such Statements and be encouraged to make those Statements.

Mr Speaker, I think on that note, we could vary the Order of Business and allow the Minister for Roads and Highways to answer his Question before we take the Minister for Foreign Affairs, because he has had the opportunity to make a Statement. So we could give an opportunity to the Minister for Roads and Highways to Answer his Question and leave.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Ayariga, it means we are closing Statements, because I had wanted to also take the First Deputy Speaker's Statement.

**Mr Ayariga:** We will come back.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** You will come back?

Leader, what is it?

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Well, Mr Speaker, not to add to the superfluity of what has already been put out by the Leader of Government Business, but Mr Speaker, he makes a profound Statement which I believe that even if it will be superfluous, I need to add my voice.

Mr Speaker, he is right.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** All right. Hon Leader—

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, just one minute. Just to support and encourage our youngsters. Mr Speaker, please bear with me.

Mr Speaker, he is right that speaking on the floor of this House is a major

challenge. I have shared with Colleagues my own experience in the early days. Mr Speaker, I would to rise, but my whole body would be shaking. I recall the source of my name being spelt Markins. I was sitting at the back there. I saw the name, but to correct was a problem. *[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, to get up and say, “Mr Speaker, the name is not Markins, but it is Markin” was a problem.

5.29 p.m.

It took the same Parliamentary Service staff and some seniors to encourage me to have my first bite, and by the grace of God, we are where we are — *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, I am, therefore, encouraging our first-timers; it does not matter how many times one makes a mistake. They should get off their shelves and also avail themselves to be trained and mentored. If one is a first-timer and he or she sees himself or herself as a master, he or she would not learn. So, they should make themselves available, get closer to the seniors, and learn.

Today, Hon Dapaah has made a history, and nobody can take that away from him — *[Hear! Hear!]*— Mr Speaker, he delivered his speech with nostalgic competence. Nobody can take it from him, and I know — *[Interruption]*— Hon Suhuyini and I know it is not easy. We should commend him. No, let us not go with that approach, but we should encourage him.

Mr Speaker, today, his constituents have seen that he is young in face, strong in bones —[*Hear! Hear!*]— This is just the beginning, and I want to encourage all from the other Side to also come up with —[*Interruption*]— I know they also have the men, but they should let us see their men.

Mr Speaker, on that score, I want to thank you, and commend my Colleague whose long-awaited Statement has finally been admitted, and he has delivered it.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, let us turn to page 3. So, in line with what the Minority Leader just said, next week, we will revisit the Backbenchers week, which is Wednesday, so that we give the Backbenchers the opportunity to also do Business in the House.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, with respect, I know that the Minister is here to attend upon the House. He cannot use this Chamber to hide from his Ministry. He has been here since 2.00 p.m. Mr Speaker, he must stay in his Ministry. He must spend time to do his ministerial work. He should pay his contractors and chase his releases at the Ministry of Finance. He should not be coming here to sit — Yes, we want him to answer our Questions, but he should fix the roads.

He has not received his releases. Since we approved the Budget, his money has not come, and he comes here. He should go and chase it. He is running

away from contractors; he cannot use Parliament to run away from contractors. He should go and pay them.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** I will call Hon Pious Kwame Nkuah to ask the Question numbered 119.

**Mr Dafeamekpor:** The Hon Member has informed me that, since filing the Question, he has had the opportunity to engage, so he intended to withdraw, but inadvertently, it has been captured on the Order Paper. I have his authority to seek your leave to withdraw the Question as advertised.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Excuse me, is he not the person who withdrew from asking a Question last week?

**Mr Dafeamekpor:** Yes. There was a chain of Questions that he asked, which were similar. If you recall, earlier last week, he withdrew one, so, this week, the other one got advertised. So, this one too would suffer the same fate, Mr Speaker.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Very well.

So, now, let us turn to Hon Vincent Ekow Assafuah, Hon Member for Old Tafo, for the Question numbered 139.

Hon Members, hold on; the Question numbered 119 is, hereby, withdrawn. Table Office, take note of that.

## ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

### MINISTRY OF ROADS AND HIGHWAYS

#### Current State of the Sinohydro Road Project

**Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh** *on behalf of Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah (NPP—Old Tafo)*: Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways details of the current state of the Sinohydro Road project in the Old Tafo Constituency, the steps being taken to ensure its completion and when it is expected to be completed.

**Minister for Roads and Highways (Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza) (MP)**: Mr Speaker, I want to put it on record that I work seven hours every day before I come to Parliament. I start work at 7 a.m.— *[Hear! Hear!]*—It is for the information of the Minority Leader that, by the time I get here, I would have done seven hours at the Ministry before coming here.

#### Background

Mr Speaker, Old Tafo is located within the Ashanti Region. The rehabilitation of roads within Old Tafo and other areas was being executed under the Sinohydro Master Project Support Agreement (MPSA) Facility, signed in 2018 by the Government of Ghana and Sinohydro Corporation of China to support priority infrastructure projects in Ghana.

## Current Programme

Mr Speaker, the Department of Urban Roads (DUR) awarded the contract titled “**Construction/Rehabilitation of Selected Roads and Interchanges in Ghana - Phase 1- Lot 2 (Kumasi Inner City Roads)**” for the rehabilitation of selected roads in beneficiary metropolis and municipalities, including Kumasi Metro, Mampong, Asokwa, Oforikrom, Effiduase, Kwadaso, Suame and Old Tafo.

The contract commenced on 21<sup>st</sup> December 2021, for completion by 2<sup>nd</sup> June, 2024.

A total of 5.7km of roads were earmarked for rehabilitation in Old Tafo:

- 4.3km of the roads have drains completed.
- 1.4km of the roads have outstanding drainage works.
- 5.7km of the roads have outstanding pavement works.

Physical progress on the project is 17 per cent. The contractor is currently not on site. The project stalled due to the Debt Restructuring Policy.

#### Steps being taken to have works resumed

The Ministry of Roads and Highways is working with the Ministry of Finance to conclude negotiations on the Chinese Commercial Loans for the resumption of funding for the project from Sinosure.



**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much.

Hon Asafo-Adjei, do you have any supplementary questions?

**Nana Ayeh:** Mr Speaker, I want to thank the Minister and ask if there can be some timelines or what the people of Old Tafo should be looking out for in terms of when final completion will be done. That is all.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Timelines, Hon Minister.

**Mr Agbodza:** Mr Speaker, when this Master Agreement came to the House many years ago, those of us who were here, the original Agreement said that Sinohydro would build the roads, and we would use the proceeds of bauxite to repay them. Unfortunately, because we were unable to mine bauxite, sell and use the proceeds to repay, the Government of the day came back and converted the so-called barter agreement to a loan. After converting it to a loan, the Government failed again in paying the loan.

Mr Speaker, the new Government is just six months in office.

4.39 p.m.

We are working hard to find the necessary steps to make sure that the sinohydro-related projects are completed. Indeed, some of the projects have since been re-awarded to other contractors who are working on it. As we said, the Minister for Finance is in the process of engaging their counterparts in China to

be able to get the issue resolved for the rest of the funds to be made available to complete the project.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much.

Hon Minister, on behalf of the House, let me thank you for attending upon the House. We are grateful to you, and you are hereby discharged.

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, the understanding was that after this, we will take the Statement of the First Deputy Speaker.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Very well. I thought the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection is itching to answer the Question.

Yes, First Deputy Speaker?

## STATEMENT

### **The Role of Statistics in Evidence-based Law and Policy Making**

**Mr Benard Ahiafor (NDC — Akatsi South):** Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to make this Statement on a matter of immense national importance, the role of statistics in evidence-based law and policy making.

Mr Speaker, official statistics are not just numbers. They are a vital component of the information system of any democratic society. They empower

governments to make informed decision, support policy formulation, guide effective resource allocation, and enable the monitoring and evaluation of socio-economic development programme and projects.

Mr Speaker, statistics also assist Parliament in making laws, exercising its oversight responsibility, and fulfilling its representative functions. Consider, for example, a national population census data on fertility rates, age structures, and population distribution are essential for determining whether to build schools, hospitals, and roads.

Similarly, accurate and timely statistics are critical for tracking our progress towards achieving the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), and for assessing the impact of national programmes, such as Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty (LEAP) initiative.

Furthermore, statistics serves as a powerful tool for accountability. Parliament relies on timely, credible, and comprehensive data to enact legislations, scrutinise policies, review budgets, and oversee the work of the Executive arm of Government. Mr Speaker, statistical systems in many developing countries, including Ghana, are often trapped in a persistent cycle of underutilisation, inadequate funding, and poor performance.

Approximately 90 per cent of the funding for Ghana Statistical Service (GSS), the central statistical and coordinating institution of the national statistical system, comes from donors.

This clearly reflects the limited values we, as a country, place on our national statistical system. The administrative data infrastructure in the country remains undeveloped, with the coordination and information sharing among institutions within the national statistical system still inadequate.

Mr Speaker, despite commendable efforts by the Ghana Statistical Service, to foster data integration among Ministries, Departments, and Agencies (MDAs), a vast amount of administrative data and statistics within the MDAs remain inaccessible to the Ghana Statistical Service. This reality compromised the oversight capacity of this House, as administrative data, critical for monitoring government programmes is either lacking or inaccessible.

Mr Speaker, this fragmentation leads to inefficiencies in service delivery, duplicated efforts and citizens frustration. Individuals may be registered differently across various platforms, complication in identification, verification, and eligibility checks. The resulting data inconsistencies increase the risk of fraud and hinder effective policy planning.

Mr Speaker, without a unified system, national statistics are weakened, data scrutiny is compromised, and the potential for digital transformation and innovation is significantly diminishing.

Mr Speaker, there is an urgent need to invest in the data system of Ghana. According to the Global Partnership for Sustainable Development Data, every dollar investment in statistics can yield

up to US\$32 in economic returns through better policy outcomes, improved governance, and smarter programme implementation.

In recognition of these challenges and opportunities, a high-level parliamentary delegation from Ghana at the invitation of the Office for National Statistics (ONS) in the United Kingdom (UK) embarked on a study tour to the UK from 19<sup>th</sup> to 23<sup>rd</sup> May, 2025. This study visit is part of a broader three-phase initiative that includes pre-engagement and post-visit implementation efforts. The goal is clear: to earn data at the centre of policy-making and legislative process of Ghana.

Mr Speaker, the delegation comprised Members of Parliament, officers of Parliament, and senior officials, including the Government Statistician from the Ghana Statistical Service. During the tour, we engaged with leading institutions, including the UK Parliament, Cabinet Offices, His Majesty's Treasury, the Bank of England, and the Office for National Statistics in Newport and London. We observed how robust statistical systems support sound governance, fiscal policy, and service delivery. The tour reinforced one truth, statistics are not optional, they are foundational to good governance.

Mr Speaker, based on our observation and lessons learnt, we identified key recommendations for both Parliament and the Ghana Statistical Service to enhance the role of data and statistics in policy-making and governance.

5.49 p.m.

These recommendations are aimed at strengthening Parliament's roles in fostering a data-driven culture and supporting national development through evidence-based policymaking. Mr Speaker, first, it is imperative that Parliament strengthens its partnership with the Ghana Statistical Service by adopting and implementing the Memorandum of Understanding and the Data-Sharing Agreement that have been developed. Doing so will ensure that Parliament has timely, secure, and reliable access to relevant data necessary for legislative oversight, informed debate and sound policymaking.

Secondly, to effectively utilise such data, we must enhance the data and analytical capacity of Members of Parliament and the Parliamentary Service staff. This can be achieved through targeted and continuous training. Building such capacity is not merely a technical requirement, it is essential to improving the quality of debate on the floor of the House, enhancing our oversight responsibilities and making policies that are grounded in facts.

Mr Speaker, to implement these efforts, we propose that Parliament enacts legislation on public sector data-sharing models after the United Kingdom's Digital Economy Act of 2017. Such a legislative framework would empower the Ghana Statistical Service to assess and utilise administrative data across various sectors for statistical purposes. This intent would improve the quality,

coherence, and timeliness of national statistics. We also recommend that Parliament works with the Ghana Tertiary Education Commission to embed data literacy as a graduation requirement in our educational system. In addition, collaboration with the Ghana Civil Service and Public Services Commission is needed to make data literacy a prerequisite for promotion within the public services. This will foster a culture of data use and evidence-informed decision making through the public sector.

Mr Speaker, for the Ghana Statistical Service, we propose several complementary reforms. The first is to amend the Ghana Statistical Service Act 2019 (Act 103), to transform the Ghana Statistical Service into an independent statistical authority with a stronger legal mandate to set national statistical standards, provide oversight, and lead the recruitment and training of statisticians across government institutions.

Mr Speaker, we urge the establishment of a dedicated parliamentary unit within the Ghana Statistical Service. This unit should be staffed with a permanent liaison officer assigned to Parliament to directly support our data needs, strengthen conditions and facilitate timely response to the House's request for data and analysis. We propose that Members of Parliament benefit from regular structured training in data literacy. This should include practical exposures to platforms such as the Ghana Statistical StatBank to build our capacity to interpret data, evaluate policies, and make evidence-based legislative decisions.

We also encourage Members to undertake the International Data Masterclasses, an online course designed to enhance their data literacy skills.

Mr Speaker, this engagement was far more than a study tour. It was a strategic investment in Ghana's democratic governance and our collective capacity as legislators. We returned with renewed commitment and practical recommendations that if embraced, can transform the way we use data in policymaking and national development.

I therefore call on this honorable House to support the implementation of these recommendations. Let us commit ourselves to building a Parliament that is data-informed, a public service that is data-literate and a governance system that is truly evidence-driven. Let us make data work for Ghana.

I thank you for giving me the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much. Unfortunately, I am not going to also allow comments on them. I will invite the Minister for Foreign Affairs to take the podium.

Hon Members, bear with me; just look at the Order Paper. There are so many Questions which are our own Questions. So, please bear with me that I am not allowing any comments. We still have other Statements to take.

So, let us turn to Page 2 —Urgent Questions and the first Question stands in the name of Hon Samuel Abu Jinapor, Member of Parliament for Damango.

Yes, Leader?

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, the First Deputy Speaker has made a very fundamental Statement on the Floor and I do not think that such a Statement by the First Deputy Speaker should go without comment. After he travelled to the UK and Ireland, accompanied by the Minority and Majority Leaders for the conference and the workshop that inspired the Statement, he comes and makes such a detailed, elaborate, fundamental, far-reaching Statement and there is no commentary, Mr Speaker, I think that you must rethink your ruling.

On that note, I plead that at least one person from each Side should, at least—but if Mr Speaker is minded to be magnanimous, he can make it two from each Side but at least one from each Side, because the Statement has been so inspiring that the former Leader is very excited and wants to make a comment.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Very well.

Hon Members, my boss has made a Statement and I am ignoring comments. So, I will allow two comments from each Side but for five minutes only; nobody is going beyond five minutes.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, we have Dr Kabiru and Prof Kingsley Nyarko.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** No problem.

I know the Minister for Education and probably the Majority Leader will also make comments.

5.59 p.m.

Please, I am going to be strict with the time; not more than five minutes. So, please, I am going to be strict on the time. Not more than five minutes.

**Mr Haruna Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker?

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** I have already said yes. Yes, Hon Minister, let me listen Hon Tiah Mahama first.

**Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama (NPP — Walewale):** Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I would first and foremost thank the Hon First Deputy Speaker, Mr Bernard Ahiafor, MP for Akatsi South for making this Statement. He has brought a topic of great importance. His Statement is a 360 Statement in the sense that it first highlights the importance of data, goes to underscore the problem with data in Africa and Ghana and then propose certain measures to addressing it.

Mr Speaker, there is a saying that data is the new gold. This is not just a metaphor, it is actually underscoring the point that data has far overrun new resources in terms of value and influence, and in the digital first global economy data is of essence. Mr Speaker, there is also another saying that Statistics are not just mere numbers. Statistics is what make data intelligible. In other words, numbers in their sense will not make any meaning unless they are

reflected in statistics and that is the point the Hon First Deputy Speaker is drawing our attention to. That to exercise our oversight responsibility effectively, it must be based on evidence.

Data utility is universal. Every single aspect of the economy and discipline relies on data. Without data identity, clarity and reliability we will not be able to plan.

Mr Speaker, there is one other thing I would like to draw our attention to. The maker of the Statement drew our attention to the fact that US\$1 investment in data has a corresponding economic return of US\$32. This is over 3,000 returns on data investment. Mr Speaker, gold or cocoa cannot give us this return. In a digital economy, we must prioritise data and that is the important point we need to highlight.

Mr Speaker, there are best practices we can learn from. That visit is one of the ways we can learn, but I would want to draw on the recommendations, and my essence is to highlight the importance of those recommendations. The maker of the Statement has actually drawn our attention to some important recommendations, but the importance of those recommendations was left maybe, for the want of time.

Mr Speaker, he recommended that we should implement the memorandum of understanding on data sharing between the Parliament of Ghana and the Ghana Statistical Service. The importance of this is that data sharing reduces the cost of data production. Mr Speaker, if

we were to have a data unit in Parliament responsible for mining data, sharing this data from relevant institutions will reduce the cost of data production in Parliament and it is an important point we need to note.

Mr Speaker, the second recommendation was to develop analytical capacity of Members of Parliament. Statistic will be a mere number in the hands of a Member of Parliament if he cannot interpret that number. Without the capacity of Members of Parliament to interpret statistics, data will not make any meaning to us. So, the capacity of Members of Parliament to have the analytical capacity to interpret data is important.

Mr Speaker, the maker of the Statement also recommended the data sharing Act. We need this particular Act in order to address the issue of data fragmentation and also to improve the universal utility of data in Ghana. With these few words, I want to thank the maker of the Statement for this brilliant Statement.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much. Yes, Hon Minister for Education?

**Mr Haruna Iddrisu (NDC — Tamale South):** Mr Speaker, I would endeavour to be very brief. This is to commend the First Deputy Speaker for his brilliant Statement on the role of statistics in evidence-based policy making.

Mr Speaker, his Statement is timely even for me as Minister for Education. Around the same time in the United Kingdom, Oxford had just published the Global Education Evidence Advisory Panel (GEEAP) which was looking at the use of language as an instruction to improve learning of children at the basic level of education. Mr Speaker, the finding which is evidence-based suggested that if children are taught in their native language, they are more likely to do better in reading and literacy. So, I want to commend him but just to also raise two other issues.

Mr Speaker, the Hon First Deputy Speaker is his own authority in law. My disagreement with him, politely, would be the Ghana Statistical Service. The Ghana Statistical Service is a creation of the 1992 Constitution in Article 185: "There shall be a Statistical Service which shall form part of the public services of Ghana." So, if he is suggesting that we now elevate it to an authority, unless of course he is suggesting that we should have an enactment to further pursue the provisions of the Constitution. This is because it is provided for there that there shall even be the Statistical Service board.

Then, Mr Speaker, in concluding, even this House will have to benefit from the Statement of the Hon First Deputy Speaker. When we are debating in this House, whether it is on the Message on the State of the Nation or the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, how much reference do all of us on both Sides make to evidence-based debate? How much reference do we make to statistics?

There can be a debate on the floor of this House and we will not find two or three Members contributing to the Budget Statement and Economic Policy with reference to the Ghana Statistical Service and its finding whether on poverty or macroeconomic performance or inflation. All we hear is that inflation is high or low. No evidence or no pointers to statistics. There can be a debate here on road infrastructure. We would need to know which parts of the country are not doing well statistically in terms of their access to quality road.

So, Mr Speaker, I hope that the Statement of the Hon First Deputy Speaker will be an awakening, even for Parliament. As he said, Parliament must make use of reliable evidence data for policymaking. What is policy? Policy must respond to a need. To examine a need, one must evaluate a particular problem that one would want policy to respond to.

For instance, there is growing teenage pregnancy in schools and we want to pass a legislation. We are now being told that the number of girls who get pregnant in school may be 12 per cent. We can only respond with legislation if we appreciate the numbers or the statistics concerned.

So, Mr Speaker, I want to commend the maker of the Statement and to encourage Parliament and Members of Parliament. The Hansard used to be an authoritative source of reference. We have all contributed in debasing the standard of the Hansard with very frivolous references we make here, that a

student cannot quote a Member of Parliament and say on this day, this is what the Hon Members said on this matter and these are statistics he provided. When we were students in the University of Ghana, Legon, we were told as political science students that the Parliamentary Hansard is an authoritative source of reference. Today, it may not be so because we do very little research, we debate not with informed evidence even on the performance of the economy or our society. With this, Mr Speaker, I commend the maker of the Statement.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Prof Nyarko?

**Prof Kingsley Nyarko (NPP — Kwadaso):** Mr Speaker, I am grateful for indulging me to add my voice to the Statement on the role of statistics in evidence-based policy making delivered by the Hon Bernard Ahiafor, my good friend, MP for Akatsi South and the First Deputy Speaker of Parliament.

Mr Speaker, this Chamber is a political Chamber. Most importantly, we must also see this Chamber as an academic environment because what we do here is watched by almost everybody in the world who has the opportunity of following proceedings. So, it is a platform for education and for that matter our comments, debates and contributions must be informed by empirical evidence that is data, and that is what the Hon First Deputy Speaker is talking about. If we want to inform policy positively, then it means that our comments, views and opinions must be grounded not in our opinions but in facts.

6.09 p.m.

Somebody said that opinions are like noses; everybody has one. But facts are sacrosanct. Our societies are governed and made better by empirical evidence. Nothing more, nothing less. We can have our opinions, but our opinion, with all due respect, do not matter. What matters most is the evidence that we have to shape thinking and thoughts, and the way of life in our quest to advancing world society.

Mr Speaker, our able First Deputy Speaker advised that we establish dedicated Parliamentary units within the Ghana Statistical Service. Mr Speaker, we must also strengthen our research department. We must expand its function and make it more functional and effective, where we can go and get more knowledge.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you, Prof.

**Prof Nyarko:** Oh, why? *[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker —

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Just wind up for me.

**Prof Nyarko:** I want to urge us all to be better Parliamentarians. We must be equipped with the skills in research, so that we can convince policymakers in order to ensure that our policies are — Mr Speaker, theories change. That is why we need to constantly update our knowledge and skills, so that we will be in tune with the realities on the ground.



Mr Speaker, because of time constraint and the pressure from Hon Rockson Dafeamekpor, I beg to yield.

Thank you.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Is it Hon Dafeamekpor or Hon Afful?

All right.

**Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor (NDC — South Dayi):** Mr Speaker, let me commend the First Deputy Speaker for this Statement. Mr Speaker, indeed, in East Africa, in fact, in Kenya, in the National Assembly, there is a whole Caucus that recently has been formed on evidence-based approach to legislation. The duty of that Caucus is to go back and assess the impact of legislation five years after it is enacted; to see the kinds of reforms and amendments that they can bring on board. So, it is a new movement in a lot of Parliaments now, and it is good.

Mr Speaker, we are already doing evidence-based policy formulation and implementation. We may not have termed it so. Indeed, when this House is approving the Common Fund formula, it is based on evidence because we use statistics to determine how much should go to South Dayi and how much should go to, for instance, Accra Metro. It is based on the statistics that we have. When we approve the National Health Insurance Scheme (NHIS) formula, it is based on the statistics that we have. In the same way, when we approve the other formulas that we do, we use statistics. In setting up health

infrastructure, building hospitals, we look at how many patients — We project that if we build this hospital, it is expected that this number of patients will patronise it over a period. So, it is such a formidable thing to adopt in all Parliaments, including the Parliament of Ghana.

Mr Speaker, indeed, in 2009, the USA, Congress actually proceeded to adopt nine ways of drafting federal legislations that are based on evidence and it has become a guide for the National Congress in drafting their legislation. It is a new movement. I am happy that Leadership got the opportunity to participate in this seminar. I am happy that they brought a Report back. Going forward, as part of the reforms in our legislations, this will be introduced. Laws are not enacted *in vacuo*. In imposing tax laws, it is based on the numbers; how many people pay taxes. Parliament does not just formulate a taxation law for the people. We know that if we do that, the number of people who pay taxes will be great. Mr Speaker, in transportation, if government constructs a road, we are able to project that; if government constructs an asphalt road of over 100 kilometres, the number of passengers that will use the road and pay toll will be such that government will be able to recoup the money spent on it. Before building courthouses, we will be able to determine and project the number of cases that will come before the judges.

Mr Speaker, I want to thank the maker of the Statement once again and pray that Leadership will essentially adopt the approach being urged on us in enacting our legislations.

With these few words, Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much.

We will now comfortably turn to Questions — Urgent Questions. Or should we go on with the Statements?

Hon Samuel Abdulai Jinapor, Member of Parliament for Damango, you may ask your Urgent Question now.

## URGENT QUESTIONS

### MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

#### **Closure of the Ghanaian Mission in Washington DC in the United States of America**

**Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor (NPP — Damongo):** Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Foreign Affairs the circumstances that led to the closure of the Ghanaian Mission in Washington DC in the United States of America.

**Minister for Foreign Affairs (Mr Samuel Okudzeto Ablakwa) (MP):** Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

Mr Speaker, I thank the Ranking Member for the question. Since I have delivered a comprehensive Statement on the matter, I would ask that *Hansard* reference the Statement I presented. [Kindly refer to column 47]. But I am open to follow-up Questions in the interest of time.

I am grateful, Mr Speaker.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much.

Yes, Hon Samuel Abdulai Jinapor, any supplementary questions?

**Mr S.A Jinapor:** Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr Speaker, I want to bring one or two matters to the attention of the Minister and ask a question on it. Mr Speaker, on 9<sup>th</sup> June, exactly 9.13 a.m., on the website of the Washington Mission, they had Madam Mawuli Dick writing and making this point and I quote:

“During this important research and transition period at the Embassy in DC, some immediate interim measures are necessary to improve the customer service”.

Mr Speaker, she goes on to talk about how one Prof Tatan Nabani, applied for a visa to come to Ghana with a group of intellectuals but because of the breakdown of service delivery at the Mission, they were unable to make the trip.

Mr Speaker, we have another, Ras Soto, who said, for example, I quote:

“Shame on the Ghana embassy in Washington D.C., and shame on the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. You disrupt service with no circumspection for it to reflect patrons and worse of all, you do not research”.

Mr Speaker, my question to the Minister is, what specific measures is he putting in place to improve upon service delivery at the Washington Mission?

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much, Hon Minister?

**Mr Ablakwa:** Well, thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Ranking Member's follow-up question is extremely important. The matter of responsiveness, engaging clientele timeously with respect, acknowledging that they have paid for a service and making sure that customer satisfaction is guaranteed are principles that we cannot compromise.

Mr Speaker, it will interest the House to know that the audit team I put together was largely because of these incessant reports of backlogs, lack of responsiveness, nobody responding to calls while people keep calling even though we are paying officials to work in these departments. We all know as a House that we spend over a GHC1 billion maintaining our 71 Diplomatic Missions abroad. So, there can be no excuse for people who are paid to work, to man telephones, to respond to emails, to carry out consular services, to ensure that our Embassies are friendly places that project the image of our country.

6.19 p.m.

What we have been telling Colleagues is that first impressions really

matter. We cannot say that we want to market our country; we want to make Ghana the gateway to Africa; we want to boost tourism, and then the first impression that visa applicants get is a certain nonchalant, and a very cavalier attitude which does not project a good image of our country. So, Mr Speaker, I can confirm that we are taking very urgent and decisive action to resolve this.

The Washington DC Mission has become too notorious when it comes to lack of responsiveness, poor customer relations, and just outright bad service which does not augur well for the image of our country. Indeed, by the time we had to shut down the Embassy, we had discovered that there was a backlog of over 2,300 visa applications that had just been ignored, and a certain culture of disrespect and disregard for applicants had really become entrenched.

I can confirm, today, Mr Speaker, that we have put together a new code of conduct, and we have sent a circular to all our embassies that we want all our phones to be reconfigured, and they had up to the 15<sup>th</sup> July to comply. Some have already complied, like our UK Mission. We want simultaneously multiple calls to come through and be picked by different staff at the same time to deal with this matter of people waiting unending and not being attended to. We have also requested that, every week, a report be submitted. We want to know the number of people who called in and the number of the calls which were picked.

We have also put in a mechanism where, with the service providers, we can directly assess the number of calls that came through, how those calls were picked, and, most importantly, Mr Speaker, we have also introduced a new system where all calls to our Diplomatic Missions are recorded for review by management, so that the reports of discourteousness, disrespect, people being rude will be subject to review, so that if we discover that a particular Foreign Service officer has been rude, discourteous, bad-mannered, then the sanctions will apply. Because the Foreign Service Regulations do not condone that kind of attitude, and there are clear sanctions that should be applied for those who engage in that unworthy conduct.

So, Mr Speaker, we are putting in place far-reaching reforms, and we believe that, with the support of this House and the hardworking Members of the Committee on Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration, we can really deal with this matter once and for all. But, Mr Speaker, having been offered the opportunity, please, permit me to take full responsibility. I would want to render an unqualified apology to all applicants to our embassies across the world who feel so frustrated and let down. We want them to know that we are still the very hospitable people we are. Ghanaians are celebrated globally for our quintessential warmth and welcoming attitude.

A few bad nuts want to tarnish that image, but they will not be allowed to tarnish our golden image. But, as Minister, I take full responsibility, and

we are working assiduously to make sure that these reports of bad treatment, lack of responsiveness, disrespect, and just outright disregard for the dignity of applicants—Because people have many countries to go to. It should be an honour to us that they choose our country, and that they want to visit us. The least we can do is to treat them with respect.

So, Mr Speaker, I take full responsibility, and we are putting in place very far-reaching measures that will resolve these matters once and for all. I do not think that these are matters that we should be defensive or partisan about. We should just be interested in the solutions, and let me also use this opportunity to commend Foreign Service officials who work hard. I recall that, recently, when I met the Ghanaian community in Madrid, Spain, they exceptionally highlighted the good services of our Foreign Service officials. They said that Ambassador Appiah-Sam and her team are doing so well. They are so responsive and welcoming. They are so professional, and they wanted the Minister to know about it.

Mr Speaker, so, it is not an all-out, if you like, bad conduct that is across the board. It is just a few people who really are not living up to the high standards of the Foreign Service of Ghana. But I know that with the efforts we are making, we shall weed out those bad nuts and resolve these matters once and for all.

I thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you. Hon Minister, if I may plead with

you, your answers should be short. It is just a plea.

Yes, Hon Samuel A. Jinapor?

**Mr S. A. Jinapor:** Thank you, Mr Speaker. I thank the Hon Minister for the assurances he has given.

Mr Speaker, with my second supplementary question, I have in my hand a letter dated 26<sup>th</sup> May, 2025 under the hand of Ms Divina A. Seanedzu, who is the Director of Administration at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. Mr Speaker, the letter sets out a wholesale transfer and movement of Foreign Service officials, beginning with Branch A officers to Branch B officers, and all the way to Branch C officers.

Mr Speaker, the indication that I have received is that this is quite unprecedented, and the manner or the extensiveness of this transfer is something which is never, probably, seen before in our Fourth Republican dispensation.

Mr Speaker, the Minister also, in his Statement, which he has relied on, mentioned Her Excellency Hajia Alima Mahama, who is a former Member of this House, former Cabinet Minister, a very distinguished public servant, who was our ambassador to Washington, and the suggestion that has been made is also how this whole matter is handled, and the references made to her seem to cast some unfair aspersions at her person and integrity.

Mr Speaker, the combined effect of these two points is giving us a report, I stand to be corrected, but this is the report I have. There is a breakdown of morale in the Foreign Service of our country. Mr Speaker, I am sure the Hon Minister would be very concerned about that if it was the case. The question to the Hon Minister is that what measures is he putting in place to position Ghana's Foreign Service as a non-partisan above board Foreign Service as it is in many developed countries, and as it should be. What measures is he putting in place to position Ghana's Foreign Service as a non-partisan Service, which will have officials who have high morale and who are prepared to sacrifice for our country? Because these Foreign Service officials go through a whole lot. They travel across the world, and they do a lot to serve our country. Will the Minister tell the House what concrete measures he intends to put in place to boost morale in the Foreign Service of our country?

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:**  
Again, Hon Minister—

Hon Members, with the questions, let us try to be—

6.29 p.m.

Hon Member, will you allow me, please? Hon Members, please.

So, I plead with those who are going to ask Questions as well, let us be straightforward with our Questions because we have so many. So, if we are

to go at the pace we are going, we may leave here around 10.00 p.m.

**Mr S. A. Jinapor:** Mr Speaker, I am fully guided, but when my good Friend, Hon Ablakwa, was here, Mr Speaker you can tell—

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** No, that is not the issue.

Yes, Hon Minister?

**Mr Ablakwa:** Well, thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I can see that the Ranking Member is really prepared for me today. *[Laughter]*

Well, Mr Speaker, let me commend the Ranking Member for his industry. I am glad that he has obtained the postings circular. It is not transfer; it is postings, and I instructed that the postings for 2025, this year's postings, should be done transparently. So, this is how we started. We set up a committee, chaired by the Chief Director. I was not involved. The Director of Finance, Director of Legal, Director of Admin, and we reps from the various B Service and A Service represented in the committee. It was very open and very transparent. For those who do not understand the workings of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, every four years, we post Foreign Service officers, typically, and there is a precedence list which is followed and it is done in a very transparent manner.

The committee presented its report and before the report was presented, they even allowed the Foreign Service staff to indicate if they were available to be

posted or not, and they did a great job. They even considered humane circumstances, like some of our females who have just given birth, and those who may have children who require special needs; they did not want to post them to countries where they would not receive that kind of specialisation for their children. So, it was really humane, very thoroughly done in a fair objective manner, and I asked that the report should be circulated, placed on our platforms, put in the file, so that everybody will see what has happened and that is why I am sure that he was able to obtain a copy of the postings list.

So far, it has been well received. There are a few petitions that have come which I would say, is normal about these processes. What I have done is that every petition received, I have invited them, listened to them, and invited management to justify why they carried out what they did. So far, all the petitioners, the few petitioners, have understood that this has been done objectively above board. There was no special interest. Nobody has been discriminated against. So, it has been done very, very professionally.

I thought that the Ranking Member would have even given me credit because when I took over the Ministry, I came under pressure that there had been recruitment of about 100 people a few days to election and they should be fired and all of that. But I said, no, I will review the process. When I reviewed the process, I noticed that they had financial clearance from the former Minister for Finance at the time and that the processes

had started before the elections, and I have kept everybody.

Nobody has been dismissed, and I must be fair to the Hon Minority Leader. He has, at least, the record of this House. I was away when I received calls that, for the first time, the Minority Leader has praised me for being very fair-handed and very objective. So, I want to assure you that morale at the Foreign Service of our country is at an all-time high.

I can give you a tall list of other things I am doing. I am restoring the duty waiver on their vehicles, so that when they are returning from postings, they can have their vehicles without paying duties on those vehicles. We are purchasing buses—

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minister?

**Mr Ablakwa:** I am concluding. We are purchasing six buses. When I met the staff on 10<sup>th</sup> February, 2025, my first day in office, the staff told me about their difficulties and challenges with transportation. I made sure that in the 2025 Budget, we made an allocation for six buses which we are procuring for our junior staff to ferry them. We are also making arrangements for their housing and all of that.

So, there is a lot we are doing to really take good care of our staff. Those who asked for extension even while they are on posting, medical support, funeral support for their spouses and loved ones, we are taking care of all of those things. So, I like to be an empathetic and

humane leader, and I can assure the Ranking Member that we will not do anything to lower the morale of our very dynamic and hardworking staff of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon S. A. Jinapor, let me give the opportunity to someone else.

**Mr S. A. Jinapor:** Mr Speaker, I am entitled to three questions; the final question. I thank you for your indulgence. But before I ask the final question, let *Hansard* capture my high commendation of the Minister for Foreign Affairs and praise for this step he took in ensuring that Ghanaians who were recruited before he came to office were not dismissed. Mr Speaker, I hope his Friend, the Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations, will take some notes from him and when he gets to Cabinet, he should make a case to the President, so that the Chief of Staff will withdraw the directive to dismiss Ghanaians across board. Well done, Minister.

Mr Speaker, the final question. The Vienna Convention on Diplomatic Relations 1961, sets out copiously the steps we should take before a Mission is closed down. Mr Speaker, further, the United States Department of State, on 24<sup>th</sup> April, 2025, issued a circular to all Missions under the hand of the Secretary of State where, again, if we go to the item numbered 10, they set out copiously what the Government of the United

States requires before a Mission will be closed down.

Mr Speaker, my question to the Minister is that what steps, as relates to the Vienna Convention on Diplomatic Relations 1961 and to this circular which I am happy to share with the Minister, did he take before closing down our Mission in Washington? Is the closure related in any form or shape to the threat issued by the Trump Administration to possibly ban Ghanaian citizens from travelling to the United States?

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Minister?

**Mr Ablakwa:** Mr Speaker, I believe we are all conversant with the Vienna Convention on Diplomatic Relations of 1961, and we need to do a distinction between leaving a country permanently, where the accreditation that you have been given, you no longer have use of it, so you are withdrawing permanently from the country, and then temporal closures, which is not a permanent withdrawal, where your accreditation is still valid. What we did, there is a clear distinction. It was just a temporal closure of our Washington Mission because we needed to carry out systemic overhauls.

I mean, the rot was just too much. It had become a cesspit that, as we have discussed earlier, we all are not proud of what was happening at the Washington Mission. So, in that case, it is very akin to what happened during COVID, where embassies temporarily shut down and

they were working from home, only skeletal stuff. Even as we speak, we have had to close our Mission in Tehran because of what is happening between Israel and Iran.

6.39 p.m.

In Israel as well, the Israeli Foreign Minister has urged Governments to ask their foreign Mission staff to stay at home. So, if you go to Tel Aviv today, our Embassy is not open, but it does not mean we have withdrawn from the country. So, there is a distinction, and I just want to clarify that.

This action was just primarily and solely because of the rot which we have uncovered. It had nothing to do with the so-called—I have to really assure the nation. There are a lot of reports about some looming ban on Ghanaians that we will not be able to travel to the United States, we are going to be banned and all of that. Let me state, this is a House of record, that Ghana has not been officially notified that we are going to be placed on any prohibition list or on any ban where our citizens cannot travel to the United States.

At this point, all of that is speculation, but as a proactive Minister, I can assure Hon Members that we are having high-level engagements. I have asked that we want to be assured that those leaks — because according to the U.S media, those were leaks, internal memos that they intercepted. We want to be assured that there is really no merit. And so far, I can tell the people of Ghana that there is no cause for alarm. That is



what we are receiving from our partners in Washington. So, I think that we will be fine, and we will continue to have very great and cordial relations with the United States of America.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, we will turn to Question 6(b). No, I will give the Hon Minority Leader the opportunity.

Hon Minority Leader, I have so many Questions to deal with today.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, maybe if you can give me just one supplementary, or I will yield to—

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Leader, I think we have similar questions relating to almost the same issue.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Very well. Mr Speaker, I have seen the Minister's Answer as contained in his Statement. I am concerned about the Foreign Service staff. As we all know, when they move out on a mission, they move with their family; spouse and children who are in school. Reading the response, it appears to me that the key person in this whole matter has been mentioned by name. And the Minister does not specifically mention that certain other foreign service staff were directly involved.

Of course, Mr Speaker, I would not take away from him his administrative supervisory mandate that if something is wrong, he ought to make certain decisions. Those ones come as a matter

of course that he wants to take a certain action. I am not going that path. I am saying that having taken that decision, which affects individuals who knew that they were on a mission, but they are left with three, two or four years, and their children are in school. What mitigating measures are in place to address some of the very expected concerns? Because if a child is in school and they are by this order to pack and go back to Ghana—I know in this House, across the aisle, family members who are affected by this. I have been talking to Colleagues who are even on the Majority Side, who may not have had the opportunity to come to the Minister, but whose siblings, cousins and relations are worried because children are now stuck. They do not know what they are doing. At the risk of saying that the measures taken were rather too harsh, would the Minister share with us how he is mitigating this?

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minister?

**Mr Ablakwa:** Well, thank you very much, Mr Speaker. The Minority Leader has asked a very important question. And let me state *ab initio* that all of us in the Foreign Service know that our circumstances can change at any time. Indeed, if one looks at the posting letters that the Foreign Service officials receive, they are told in very clear language that they can be recalled or can be cross-posted at any point in time. So there is a certain psychological preparedness that these things can happen.

Having said that, I am not one to carry out these measures without a

human face, as we call it. When the instruction for recall was issued, I received a number of petitions on humanitarian grounds. There was one Foreign Service official who had been involved in a fire accident, who had gone to buy fuel from a fuel filling station some years back. And it is a miracle she survived. So she is receiving care in the United States, has gone through 13 surgeries. I am sure that the former Deputy Minister, Mr Ampratwum-Sarpong, knows her very well.

When her petition came to my attention, I immediately said on humanitarian grounds, she should stay because she even has outstanding surgeries; eight more surgeries. I would not want the cause of the action of someone else. It was clear to me that she was not anywhere close to what Kwarteng and his collaborators were doing. Then there is also another confidential secretary who petitioned. She is almost nine months pregnant, and we do not want a pregnant lady to be compelled to travel by air that distance, about 13 hours. So again, the internal committee we set up, finding out that she was not close, we have exempted her and she is staying.

So this is just a practical way of explaining that we are implementing this with a human face so that the Foreign Service officials do not think that we are just out to get them, or we want to be draconian. That is not what is at play. In the case of children, spouses and all of that, we are looking at these matters on a case-by-case basis. But as I pointed out earlier, the evidence is overwhelming.

The management team that carried out this investigation has concluded that there is no way Fred Kwarteng could have done what he did all these years alone, as a lone wolf, that there is absolutely no way. No, there is evidence.

They talked about the welfare fund, which they made Fred Kwarteng to be transferring money — it is all in the report. We will make the report available; the welfare fund that they were benefiting from and those who allowed him to be carrying passports out and all of that. So, if we delve into it—I have been quite measured not to mention names and people's complicity and all of that. But I am sure that when Members read the Economic and Organised Crime Office (EOCO) report —There is an internal report, but we have also invited EOCO to carry out more forensic investigations. So let me just assure the Hon Leader that we are balancing between the need to be ruthless in fighting corruption, conflict of interest, naked abuse of office, and also doing it with a human face so that vulnerable people are not disadvantaged. So it is a delicate balance which we are conscious of.

6.49 p.m.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister for Foreign Affairs in his Statement, which he requested same to be adopted as his answer to question 6(a), makes reference to the Report. In fact, it says “the Report he commissioned is attached”. Since this is the House of records, and in his response, he said he will bring it. I just would want to confirm

whether he has the report. In the Statement, he made reference to the report, and said, ‘which is hereby attached, but what was distributed to us does not have the report. So, may we have a copy tabled? —[Interruption]— Yes, what I am saying is that he said he would attach, but he did not table it. So, if he can table it now, because it is something that he referred to in his Statement, that the report is hereby attached. It is his words. So, if he can table it, it will become part of the records of the House, then we can rely on it to do further deliberations. Mr Speaker, whilst he takes his time to look for the report — Yes, I needed this copy for — Do you have it there?

Mr Speaker, may he do the formal tabling, then I take a copy. I want to make reference to something in it, then the transmitters can make it available.

**Mr Ablakwa:** Mr Speaker, the Hon Minority Leader is clearly misconstruing paragraph 7. If he pays attention to paragraph 7, I speak of the 2019 query. So, in paragraph 7, I was referring to the query. I said I have here a copy of the 2019 query, which I am able to present to this House and I have a copy. I even read the query. So, I am happy to lay it. So, it is the query I was referring to, not the report. But I am also happy to make the report available later to him because I do not have that here. But paragraph 7 was about the query.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, I am quite curious. In the sense that the mainstay of the action was founded on the outcome of the audit. I would have

thought that the Minister would have fortified himself without a demand from this House. But, Mr Speaker, he is a man who is representing us in that space and we would respect his promise to make that report available to us. So, I would not belabour the point.

Now, the Hon Minister, has used that principle of collective liability to take a decision by which innocent people are also affected, and refers to this general clause we find in contract— the termination clauses. But the test —there is always a test to the triggering of these clauses. I agree with him that, when one is posted, there is a provision that you can be recalled, reposted and all. But there is a test to it. It must be within reasonable contemplation. Not on matters suddenly arising. He talked about human face to solving the problem. I may want you to pursue that rather forcefully because there is really an overwhelming outcry, lamentation, that has come to my attention. I would want the Hon Minister to continue to pursue, to see how he can solve that problem for our compatriots who are there. That said, may he tell us, in the report he received, was there any aspect that specifically, without any equivocation, without ambiguity, point to the fact that the embassy officials, as well as the head of the Mission, became aware that the company that was contracted belonged to the gentleman he referred to in his report. Was there any such specific evidence to that effect?

**Mr Ablakwa:** Mr Speaker, the simple answer is yes. The committee discovered that there were some officials

at the embassy who knew that GTC belonged to Mr Fred Kwarteng.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, I say that for us in the political space, the only asset we have is our reputation. I am happy to hear that the Hon Minister says that some staff were aware. But I want some clarity. These staff who were aware, were they at the level of decision-making? Or they were staff at the embassy who were not part of the decision-making process of awarding the contract? I asked this because, as the Mr Jinapor said, the respected ambassador who has ended his service to the nation far away in America, served as a Member of Parliament, a respected lawyer, and a Minister, who ended her career as a political diplomat. I must admit that he has not mentioned her directly in his response. That I can concede but I want him to clarify whether those who came under his radar as having knowledge of the company were part of decision-making.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minister.

**Mr Ablakwa:** Mr Speaker, the report indicates clearly that there were some in management and some lower on the food chain who knew about it and they will even help him cart the passports to his office 40 minutes away from the Mission. I said that the explosive report, which will be interesting reading, will be made available to this House.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Leader?

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, I am not asking any more questions. I believe that when we finally get the report, we can interrogate the issues. So, I will rest my case pending the tabling of the report.

May the Minister indicate how soon?

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you. Let us turn to question (b).

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, I said may the Minister indicate how soon, based on his own —Because he cannot have it readily with us. He says he has it. Because he is busy.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minister?

**Mr Ablakwa:** Mr Speaker, I am happy to present the report as early as tomorrow.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Tomorrow?

**Mr Ablakwa:** Yes, we have Cabinet meeting tomorrow —

6.59 p.m.

**Mr Ablakwa:** Yes, we have Cabinet Meeting tomorrow, but after the Cabinet Meeting, I would be here to present the Report.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Very well. I am reading the mood of the House.

We will now turn to Question B, standing in the name of Hon Laurette Korkor Asante, Member of Parliament for Atiwa West.

### **Ten Per cent Tariffs Imposed on Ghanaian Exports**

**Mrs Laurette Korkor Asante (NPP — Atiwa West):** Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Foreign Affairs the outcome of the meeting between the Ministry and the Ambassador of the United States of America regarding the 10 per cent tariff imposed by the United States of America on Ghanaian exports.

Thank you.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minister?

**Minister for Foreign Affairs (Mr Samuel Okudzeto Ablakwa) (MP):** Mr Speaker, let me commend the Hon Korkor Asante her Question.

I am pleased to present to this august House, the key outcomes of the bilateral engagement between the Government of Ghana and the United States of America concerning the 10 per cent tariff imposed on Ghanaian exports following my invitation to the U.S. Ambassador. I can confirm that on 7<sup>th</sup> April, 2025, I, together with the Deputy Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry, the Hon Sampson Ahi, and technocrats of both Ministries, the Ministries of Foreign Affairs and Trade, Agribusiness and

Industry met with Her Excellency Virginia E. Palmer, the United States Ambassador to Ghana, to address Ghana's concerns regarding the economic impact of the tariff and explore possible mitigation strategies.

Mr Speaker, Ghana and the USA enjoy over 60 years of robust bilateral relationship built on trade, investment, security cooperation, and diplomatic exchanges. Over the past decade, Ghana has emerged as a key trading partner for the USA, with exports exceeding US\$1.2 billion in 2024 spanning critical sectors such as cocoa, apparel, agro-processing, timber, and manufactured goods. It remains one of the top destinations for U.S. foreign direct investment in sub-Saharan Africa, attracting approximately US\$5 billion in investment across agriculture, manufacturing, construction, and tourism between 1994 and 2024.

However, on 2<sup>nd</sup> April, 2025, the U.S. Government, under an Executive order invoking the International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA), imposed a 10 per cent blanket tariff on imports from 57 countries, including Ghana, on key export sectors, particularly cocoa, timber, agro-processing, and apparel, citing potential foreign exchange losses, job reductions, and economic strain on exporters. This policy, aimed at reducing trade deficits and boosting domestic manufacturing, is expected to significantly disrupt Ghana's trade flow with the United States of America. As a World Trade Organisation (WTO) member, Ghana is committed to fair and transparent trade practices and

views the blanket tariff as a potential violation of the most favoured nation principle under Article 1 of General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade (GATT), which requires equal and non-discriminatory tariff treatment among WTO members. Our engagement sought to clarify the tariff's implications and advocate for Ghana's interests.

The key outcomes of the engagement:

Mr Speaker, following deliberations with Ambassador Palmer, the Ambassador clarified that the 10 per cent tariff imposition exempts some products, such as oil and gas and energy-related products that Ghana exports to the United States.

The following outcomes emerged:

### **Negotiations for cocoa and cocoa derivative exemptions**

Ghana raised serious concerns over the adverse impact of the tariff on cocoa exports, a sector that contributes significantly to Ghana's economy. The U.S. Ambassador acknowledged Ghana's concerns and cited trade deficits of US\$240 million with Ghana and the broader trade imbalances as a rationale for the tariff. The meeting discussed the possible exemption of other sectors such as cocoa and its derivatives, such as cocoa butter, paste, powder, and garments. The Government of Ghana will pursue follow-up high-level diplomatic engagements in Washington, D.C. to formalise discussions on this exemption which could protect a

significant portion of Ghana's exports from additional costs.

The impact on The Africa Growth and Opportunity Act (AGOA). The Africa Growth and Opportunity Act benefits about 6,700 products to the U.S. market and we do that duty-free access. We raised concerns about the tariff's undermining effects on AGOA. The Ambassador confirmed that AGOA remains in force, but Ghanaian products under AGOA will still be subjected to the 10 per cent tariff. Ghana expressed strong reservations about the erosion of AGOA's trade advantages and reaffirmed its commitment to advocating for AGOA's renewal beyond its scheduled expiration on 30<sup>th</sup> September, 2025.

The U.S. side also raised concerns about their businesses in Ghana, and some of the concerns were about a 15 per cent Value Added Tax (VAT) on imported automobiles. They also cited the Mining Sector Procurement Regulatory Amendment, which was effected on the 6<sup>th</sup> January, 2025.

### **Tariff preferences on agricultural exports**

Mr Speaker, the U.S. expressed interest in exploring a Free Trade Agreement with Ghana, similar to Ghana's existing trade partnership with the European Union and the United Kingdom, under the Ghana-EU Economic Partnership Agreement and the Ghana-UK Trade Partnership Agreement, respectively. A structured trade agreement could potentially replace AGOA benefits and establish a

reciprocal tariff regime ensuring long-term stability in Ghana-U.S. trade relations. Ghana will assess the feasibility of this proposal potentially through a line-by-line tariff review that aligns with its commitments under the WTO and regional integration frameworks, such as the African Continental Free Trade Area, in consultations with key stakeholders and industry players ensuring it aligns with national trade objectives.

### **Further commitments**

Ambassador Palmer reaffirmed her dedication to preserving Ghana-U.S. relations despite the 10 per cent tariff imposition. Her commitments include high-level advocacy in Washington, D.C., expanded stakeholder engagement, and sustained bilateral cooperation.

### **Ghana's policy response**

Mr Speaker, as a nation, Ghana remains committed to proactive diplomatic engagements to address the challenges posed by the new tariff regime. The Ministry of Foreign Affairs and the Ministry of Trade, Agribusiness and Industry in consultation with the His Excellency the President of the Republic, jointly issued a press release on Monday, April 7<sup>th</sup>, 2025, to reassure stakeholders of Government's commitment to dialogue with the USA to improve their trade relations. Stakeholder engagement with all key stakeholders, including industry players, trade associations, exporters, and academia, was held on Thursday, April 10<sup>th</sup>, 2025, at the African Continental Free Trade Area Secretariat,

which concluded with the suggestion that the Government should ease the cost of doing business and explore alternative markets to export Ghanaian products among others.

Our approach moving forward includes strengthening our trade diversification through the African Continental Free Trade Area framework. To mitigate the impact of a 10 per cent tariff and strengthen economic resilience, Ghana will accelerate efforts to expand its trade engagement under the African Continental Free Trade Area ensuring reduced dependency on U.S. exports and creating new markets for Ghanaian products within Africa. This strategic approach aims to expand intra-Africa trade, promote regional market access, bolster local production and export capacity and strengthen economic resilience.

Mr Speaker, I can confirm that a lot of these initiatives have begun in earnest and we are pursuing this diversification and also signing agreements with other markets and other countries, so that the impact of this 10 per cent tariff is really not felt by the Ghanaian people.

In conclusion, Mr Speaker, Ghana remains committed to preserving its trade interests and fostering strong economic ties with the United States. Through strategic diplomatic engagement, bilateral negotiations, and proactive trade diversification, we seek to mitigate the impact of the 10 per cent tariff and ensure a resilient competitive trade environment for Ghanaian exporters. I assure this House that Government will

continue with its engagement with the U.S. to secure favourable trade agreements, protect Ghana's economic priorities and reinforce our position in global commerce.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Korkor Asante, pardon me, I will give you only one supplementary question.

**Mrs Asante:** Mr Speaker, I believe that I am entitled to three supplementary questions.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Let us hear you.

7.09 p.m.

**Mrs Asante:** Can the Hon Minister clarify? I think I heard him mention that when he had the meeting with the Ambassador to the United States of America, they countered that we have a VAT, so did he present any counter-proposal or offer to them or has he taken any steps for a reduction or even a waiver? This is because I know some countries have been exempted.

**Mr Ablakwa:** Mr Speaker, that is an important supplementary question about measures for mitigation. Mr Speaker, we have decided that we will go into a special trade agreement with the United States of America. I can confirm to the House that, only last week, the Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry led a delegation to begin talks with the United States of America because they have demonstrated that they are open to signing separate bilateral agreements.

The United Kingdom has just concluded one which both countries are describing as a win-win agreement. So, we are also taking full advantage of that opportunity. Those discussions only just begun last week, so I can make a commitment to be regularly updating the House and Hon Member on the progress made. I also will assure the nation that when we conclude those negotiations, we will certainly make the outcome public.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, at your pleasure, can we continue with the Oral Answers to Questions before we come to Hon Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources?

All right, so, Hon Patrick Boamah, you will take the Question numbered 77.

## ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

### MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

#### Cost Structure in the Pricing of an Ordinary Ghanaian Passport

**Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah (NPP—Okaikwei Central):** Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I beg to ask the Minister for Foreign Affairs the cost structure in the pricing of an ordinary Ghanaian passport.

**Minister for Foreign Affairs (Mr Samuel Okudzeto Ablakwa) (MP):** I am grateful, Mr Speaker. Let me commend the distinguished Mr Patrick Boamah for his Question.



I appreciate the opportunity to address this Hon House to provide clarity on the cost structure underpinning the production and issuance of a standard passport booklet. This is in line with our commitment to transparency and sound financial governance in the delivery of essential public services.

The total cost incurred in producing a single standard passport booklet currently stands at \$18.54, equivalent to GH¢278.10, using an exchange rate of \$1 to GH¢15, and that was the exchange rate at the time the agreement was signed with Biometric Travel Solutions (BTS) Limited.

This total cost is comprised of two key components:

- i. Cost of the passport booklet: This refers to the physical production of

| <b>Cost Buildup for a std passport booklet</b> | <b>Cost \$</b>  | <b>Cost GHS</b> | <b>Ex. Rate</b> |
|------------------------------------------------|-----------------|-----------------|-----------------|
| Passport booklet                               | \$ 11.00        | 165.00          | \$1 = 15        |
| Operational cost per unit                      | \$ 7.54         | 113.10          |                 |
|                                                | <u>\$ 18.54</u> | <u>278.10</u>   |                 |

Mr Speaker, although the underlying dollar-denominated costs remain constant, the recent appreciation of the Ghanaian cedi from GH¢15 to approximately GH¢11 to the US dollar has led to a significant reduction in the cedi-equivalent cost of producing each passport. This favourable exchange rate movement has created fiscal space, resulting in savings in our local currency terms.

In line with our prudent financial management practices, these savings will not go unused. Instead, they will be strategically reinvested to improve and expand the delivery of passport services

the secure booklet, including specialised printing and embedded security features. The unit cost is \$11.00, which translates to GH¢165.00, at the time when the exchange rate was US\$1 to GH¢15.

- ii. Operational cost per unit: This amounts to \$7.54, or GH¢113.10, and includes a range of essential services required for passport issuance. These are:

- Maintenance of biometric and IT infrastructure,
- Courier services for document delivery,
- Printing
- Personnel

across the country. A portion of the realised gains will be directed towards courier services as part of our ongoing reforms, thereby enhancing the efficiency and reliability of passport delivery, particularly for applicants outside major urban centres.

I am, therefore, delighted to confirm that the Mahama Administration remains committed to its pledge of reducing the passport fees from GH¢500 to GH¢350 for the 32-page booklet. It will be recalled that the previous Administration, last year, carried out a 400 per cent increment in passport application fees which was not well received by the Ghanaian public

and led to a considerable decrease in the patronage of passport services. A new fees and charges amendment will soon be presented to this august House for approval from GH¢500 to GH¢350.

**Mr Boamah:** Mr Speaker, I thank the Hon Minister for his elaborate Answer. I am satisfied, especially with the concluding part of his Answer with regards to the fact that he will come to our Committee with amendment to the Fees and Charges (Miscellaneous Provision), 2022 (Act 1080). That led to the filing of this Question, so I thank you very much for the opportunity.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** I wish every owner of a Question would just do what Hon Patrick Boamah has done; after the main Question, probably one supplementary question—So, we will turn to the Question numbered 102, which stands in the name of Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor.

Deputy Ranking Member?

### **Response of the Ministry to Foreign Policy of USA**

**Nana Asafo-Agyei Ayeh on behalf of (Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor) (NPP — Damongo):** Mr Speaker I beg to ask the Minister for Foreign Affairs the response of the Ministry to the foreign policy of the United States of America under President Donald Trump, particularly the withdrawal from the Paris Agreement.

**Mr Ablakwa:** Mr Speaker, since the re-emergence of President Donald Trump

as President of the United States in January 2025, the world has witnessed various foreign policy shifts from his government, in accordance with his campaign promise of placing America first. These policy shifts have ushered in significant political and legal shifts, impacting both domestic policies and international relations. On the international front, President Trump's return to power has led to shifts in US global engagement. While he has expressed reluctance to start new wars, he has indicated a focus on tariffs and economic nationalism.

His administration is expected to continue his previous foreign policy strategies, including strengthening alliances under transactional terms and pushing for less reliance on multilateral agreements. While some of these new policies are still unfolding, others are yet to be accompanied by official documents that will allow for detailed studies and appropriate reactions. One of these key policy shifts under the Trump administration has been the withdrawal of the United States from the Paris Agreement. Since assuming office in January, the Trump Administration has focused on:

- a. Adoption of hardline positions on the Israeli-Palestinian conflict and the Ukraine war;
- b. Suspension of international aid (USAID) and withdrawal of the United States from multilateral arrangements, including the World Health Organisation;

- c. Reinstating stricter immigration policies, including mass deportation;
- d. Pushing tax cuts and deregulation to stimulate the economy, i.e. the imposition of trade tariffs; and
- e. Attempting to roll back Biden-era climate and social policies.

Mr Speaker, the Paris Agreement was adopted on 12<sup>th</sup> December, 2015 during the 21<sup>st</sup> Conference of the Parties (COP 21) to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC). It is a landmark international accord aimed at strengthening global response to climate change.

7.19 p.m.

It seeks to substantially reduce greenhouse gas emissions as a means of limiting global temperature rise during this century to well below two degrees Celsius above pre-industrial levels while pursuing efforts to limit the temperature increase even further to 1.5 degrees Celsius. The Agreement, therefore, includes commitments from all the major emitting countries to cut their climate pollution and to strengthen those commitments over time.

The Agreement also provides an avenue for developed countries to assist developing countries in their climate mitigation and adaptation efforts. It has made provisions for transparent monitoring and reporting as well as getting countries to live up to their individual and collective climate goals.

The Paris Agreement has underpinned international climate action for nearly a decade. The goals and strategies it set out are critical to maintaining a stable climate, which is the foundation of successful societies and economies. As of this year, 2025, a total of 197 countries have endorsed the Agreement, which came into force on 4<sup>th</sup> November, 2016.

### **The United States of America and The Paris Agreement**

Mr Speaker, the Paris Agreement was negotiated with the United States, a major stakeholder in the global climate change discourse, firmly in mind. The United States formally joined the Paris Agreement in September 2016. However, upon assuming office in his first tenure, President Donald Trump in June 2017, announced the withdrawal of the United States from the Agreement. But in accordance with the provisions of the Agreement, the withdrawal took effect on 4<sup>th</sup> November, 2020, a day after the U.S. Presidential elections. On 19<sup>th</sup> February, 2021, the United States, under the then newly elected President, Joe Biden, rejoined the Paris Agreement. But as we all know, President Donald Trump, in his second term, has once again announced the withdrawal of the United States from the Agreement. It has become quite of a ping-pong.

Mr Speaker, the Paris Agreement stipulates that any nation's withdrawal takes effect one year after an official notice has been submitted to the Secretary General of the United Nations. In the case of the United States, therefore, the earliest effective date of

official withdrawal from the Agreement will be sometime in January 2026. After that date, the country will no longer be bound by any obligations under the Agreement.

### **Ghana's Position and Response to the U.S. Withdrawal**

Mr Speaker, while the Government of Ghana finds the decision of the United States to withdraw from the Paris Agreement regrettable, it acknowledges and respects the sovereign rights of the country to join or withdraw from any multilateral arrangement, in line with its policy priorities.

The Government of Ghana would have wished that the United States remained in the Paris Agreement. This is because the United States is an important player in the global climate change discourse, given its size, industrial base, and global influence. This decision, when it comes into effect, in January next year, will make it significantly more difficult to achieve the ambitions of emission reduction across the world. The decision also has the propensity to disturbingly garner support in other countries and, in the process, undermine the global consensus that has been built around the Paris Agreement over the past decade. This could weaken the existing multilateral climate platform.

As a result, one of the immediate responses of the Government of Ghana to the announcement of withdrawal by the United States from the Paris Agreement is to utilise every opportunity at both bilateral and multilateral fora, to

appeal to the US Government to reconsider its decision. Working with the larger international community, we hope to continue to engage the United States on the matter and to highlight the direct impacts of the changing climate on our world – from storm surges, to heatwaves, melting glaciers, and massive crop failures. In diplomacy, we cannot forget the power of persuasion as a tool for change, no matter how grim a situation may look.

Mr Speaker, if history is to serve as a guide, we can be hopeful that even if our persuasion fails and the withdrawal from the Paris Agreement goes into effect in January 2026, the United States could in future, rejoin the Agreement under a different person. The country rejoined the Paris Agreement in February 2021, right after the election of President Joe Biden, and there is no reason to doubt that under a different dispensation, the United States may not consider returning to the multilateral arena.

Besides, it is important to point out that the 21<sup>st</sup> January, 2025 Executive Order of President Trump does not withdraw the United States from the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC), which is the treaty established in 1992 to oversee the international climate negotiation process. As a result, the United States retains its right to vote in the Conference of Parties as well as its reporting obligations under the UNFCCC after it has exited the Paris Agreement in 2026. This means that there is still some avenue, although limited, for the United

States to remain engaged on climate change.

On its part, the Government of Ghana will continue to fulfil its obligations under the Paris Agreement and to support global initiatives to promote the climate change agenda. Platforms such as the BRICS Summit under the Brazilian presidency in July, and the G20 Summit under South Africa's presidency in November, could serve as useful avenues to push the agenda of encouraging other major carbon emitters to remain committed to climate action and to increase their national pledges. In other words, over 190 other countries, representing approximately 90 per cent of global emissions, that have not withdrawn from the Paris Agreement, need to be fully engaged to remain committed to the cause.

Ghana will also deepen her engagement with like-minded countries, regional blocs, and international organisations, such as the European Union, the African Union, and the Climate Vulnerable Forum — whose Secretariat is based here in Accra — to continue to champion efforts to achieve the climate change targets. These partnerships would help to sustain progress towards Ghana's own climate goals and unlock new avenues for cooperation and support.

Mr Speaker, His Excellency President John Dramani Mahama has shown visionary leadership through the appointment of Hon Issifu Seidu as Ghana's first-ever Minister of State for Climate Change and Sustainability. This

appointment will see the Minister lead efforts in shaping and implementing policies that align with Ghana's development goals, while ensuring strict adherence to the country's obligations to the global climate change agenda. By establishing a dedicated Ministry for Climate Change and Sustainability, Ghana is positioning herself as a leading voice in shaping continental and global discussions on the subject. This will also allow Ghana to focus particular attention on how to access international climate finance mechanisms, such as the Green Climate Fund, Loss and Damage Fund, and Adaptation Fund for development, while fostering public-private partnerships to fund sustainability projects.

Mr Speaker, to conclude, Ghana's foreign policy approach to global climate governance has remained consistent, resilient, and forward-looking. The country continues to champion climate action, sustainable development, and multilateral cooperation, regardless of the political shifts by key global players like the United States. Ghana would, therefore, continue to collaborate with all partners committed to the Paris Agreement to ensure a climate-secure future.

Mr Speaker, I thank you.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Asafo-Adjei Ayeh, are you not tired? All right, let me give you one.

**Mr Ayeh:** Mr Speaker, I only seek to ask that Ghana and the United States are members of the Forest Climate Leadership Platform. In fact, we both co-

chair, and there is a plan to end forest loss and land degradation. I want to ask that the United States having pulled from this Paris Agreement, what would the Minister do to ensure that that project, the land loss and the forest degradation, will still continue, or what would he do to get them to do that? That is all.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Before the Hon Minister answers, Hon Members, we have spent more than five hours in the Chamber, and per our Standing Orders, I should seek your indulgence to continue or allow the House to continue sitting. So, we will continue sitting beyond the five hours.

Yes, Hon Minister?

**Mr Ablakwa:** Mr Speaker, let me assure Hon Asafo-Adjei Ayeh that we will continue to engage with the United States at that forum. As I pointed out in my Response, the United States, fortunately, has not withdrawn from the UNFCCC which came into force in 1992. So, we continue to collaborate through that framework and we are confident that the objectives that we have set can continue to be pursued at a bilateral level.

7.29 p.m.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, the owner of the Question numbered 128 is not here.

Hon Member for Suaman, let us hear you.

## **Timeline for Establishing Passport Offices in the Remaining Six Regions**

**Mr Frederick Addy on behalf of Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah (NPP— Old Tafo):** Thank you Mr Speaker, I come under Order 88(3). I have the authority of the Hon Member and beg to ask the Minister for Foreign Affairs to provide a timeline for establishing passport offices in the remaining six regions that currently do not have them in line with the Government's commitment to expanding passport application centres.

**Minister for Foreign Affairs (Mr Samuel Okudzeto Ablakwa) (MP):** Mr Speaker, as part of efforts to decentralise passport delivery and ensure equitable access to passport services, the Ministry plans to establish passport applications centres in the following regions;

- a. Savannah Region
- b. Bono East Region
- c. Ahafo Region
- d. Oti Region
- e. Western North Region
- f. North East Region

Additionally, we have initiated the construction of an application centre for Bolgatanga in the Upper East Region. A technical team recently visited four (4) out of the six (6) new regions. As an interim measure, we will collaborate with the Regional Coordinating Councils for suitable spaces to begin providing

services while we take steps to construct more permanent passport application centres hopefully from next year. It is pertinent to note that the only permanent application centre we have is the annex building located at Kinbu in Accra.

Currently, citizens residing in these 6 new regions and the Upper East Region must travel long distances to access passport services in other regional capitals. This situation imposes logistical, financial, and time-related burdens on applicants and undermines the Ministry's mandate to provide efficient, inclusive, and citizen-centered service delivery.

The existing PACs in nearby regions are currently under pressure due to high volumes of applications from both residents and non-residents. The establishment of new PACs in the underserved regions will decentralise service delivery, ease congestion at current centres, and improve overall efficiency in passport processing and issuance timelines.

This project supports key national development goals, including the government's digital transformation agenda and its commitment to balanced regional development. By extending the passport system infrastructure to all 16 regions, the Ministry will contribute to creating a more inclusive digital identity framework, ensuring that no region is left behind in the national service architecture.

## **Strategic Alignment and Justification**

Mr Speaker, the initiative aligns with the Ministry's broader digitisation and decentralisation strategy aimed at improving service coverage, operational efficiency, and public satisfaction. The establishment of these PACs is a significant step toward achieving the following:

- a. Decongesting existing PACs in overburdened regions.
- b. Reducing travel time and associated costs for applicants in underserved areas.
- c. Increasing application amount and revenue from passport services.
- d. Supporting national efforts toward inclusive development and public service decentralisation.

## **Project Scope and Timeline**

The scope of work includes site identification and acquisition (where necessary), infrastructure development or refurbishment, ICT and biometric equipment installation, staff training, legal and operational structuring, and public sensitisation.

A four-member delegation was dispatched from the Ministry Headquarters to undertake a field mission from 28<sup>th</sup> to 30<sup>th</sup> May 2025. The primary objective of the mission was to engage relevant stakeholders and assess the suitability of potential facilities for the establishment of Passport Application Centres (PACs).

in the six regions currently without these facilities. The delegation was able to visit and assess four of the targeted regions during this initial phase of the mission, namely Savannah, North East, Bono and Ahafo. The other two regions would be assessed in the coming days.

The field mission yielded several encouraging outcomes that demonstrate strong prospects for the successful establishment of Passport Application Centres (PACs) in the six (6) remaining regions. In all four (4) regions visited, the regional and municipal authorities expressed enthusiastic support for the Ministry's decentralisation agenda. The engagements revealed not only institutional goodwill but also a deep appreciation of the importance of bringing passport services closer to citizens in underserved areas.

Mr Speaker, we are optimistic that by close of year, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs will provide interim PACs in all regions of Ghana. Steps will be taken from 2026 to construct permanent PACs.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much. So, we will turn to — Hon Minister for Foreign Affairs, on behalf of the House, let me thank you for attending upon the House to respond to Questions from your Colleagues. We thank you and you are hereby discharged.

Hon Members, I am suspending the House for 20 minutes. Please indulge me.

7.36 p.m. — *Sitting suspended.*

7.43 p.m. — *Sitting resumed.*

[MR SECOND DEPUTY SPEAKER  
IN THE CHAIR]

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, let us resume our seats and let me thank you for indulging me for ten minutes. There is a saying that if you are to receive a blow, the earlier you receive it, the better. *[Laughter]*

So, Hon Members, we are turning to Question numbered 18 and the Question stands in the name of Hon Mavis Nkansah-Boadu. I saw her here.

Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Hon Habib Iddrisu, I think the Ministers themselves have—

Hon Kabiru Mahama, what did he say?

**Dr Mahama:** Their people are not there. They can even be counted.

*[Laughter]*

**Mr Dafeamekpor:** Mr Speaker, just to assist you to manage the House, the Ministers have been here for some time, given the exigencies. So, we want to pray that we do not take supplementary questions and considering also that the Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources has a lot of the Questions, we want to take the one in the name of Hon Mavis Nkansah-Boadu for the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection to respond quickly, then we can have time to take the Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources. He has a lot. Mr Speaker, I pray that we



do not take supplementary questions, so we can speed things up. That is why I am praying, Speaker. Hon Habib Iddrisu, let us make progress. Do not cook anything.

**Alhaji Habib Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, the Majority Chief Whip knows what to do. Mr Speaker, we have an Urgent Question. We normally tackle Urgent Questions before we come to Questions.

We have tackled the Urgent Questions in respect to the Minister for Foreign Affairs. But there is an extra Urgent Question for the Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources. So, if he is going to make an application, he should reach out to us and make the application as such—No, but you cannot jump Urgent Question and come to say the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection is here. The Minister responsible for Works, Housing and Resources, has been here since afternoon. Even though she is our Colleague, since afternoon, the Minister for Works, Housing and Resources has been here and he briefed us on the flooding issue and then he was still relaxing. So, even if there is something to give him after briefing, he should handle his Question. I do not know the urgency of the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection Questions, but I think the Urgent Question we have on our Order Paper should be for the Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources and if the Majority Chief Whip wants to make an application to vary, that we should leave Urgent Question and come to Question, he should do so and he cannot also set the rule for himself. Our Standing Orders

permit us for follow-up questions. So, it does not lie on him, the Majority Chief Whip to dictate to us that we should not ask urgent supplementary questions. That is all left to you. It is in our Orders and I do not think that we are invoking Order 5 where we have to stand down our rules.

Mr Speaker, I think that if Members are entitled to something, they should be given the opportunity to. But for the fact that the Majority Chief Whip thinks we have been here for long and we should not ask supplementary questions, I do not think it is right and I think that we should tackle the Urgent Question and if he wants to come to the normal Questions and he wants the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection to come, then he makes such an application. But for now, we should tackle the Urgent Question.

**Mr Dafeamekpor:** Mr Speaker, there is reasonableness in everything. Sometimes in the evenings, your mood changes. *[Laughter]*

His mood has changed. He are litigating this matter. He should support me and say that because there is a single Question standing for two grades. So, we take that quickly. Then, we can have—Then also Affirmative Action so, ladies first—

The Hon Minister for Works, Housing and Resources, thinks that he is—

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Anyway. Hon Members—

**Mr Dafeamekpor:** Mr Speaker, long story short, we pray that we vary like we did before.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** I will manage it.

**Mr Dafeamekpor:** Yes, Mr Speaker, please do so.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** I believe the Hon Minister for Works, Housing and Resources is enjoying proceedings. I can foresee that.

*[Laughter]*

**Mr Dafeamekpor:** So, Speaker, we are entirely in your hand. Let us manage this quickly so that we can go and come back tomorrow.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Just cooperate with me to manage the House. If I give you one supplementary question, please take it. It is enough.

Hon Habib Iddrisu, do not shake your head. I saw you shaking your head. Yes.

**Dr Mahama — rose —**

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Are you taking the Question for Hon Mavis Nkansah-Boadu?

**Dr Mahama:** Mr Speaker, I have the leave of the Hon Member to ask this Question. I am then seeking also for your leave to ask that Question on her behalf.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** All right. Let us hear you.

## MINISTRY OF GENDER, CHILDREN AND SOCIAL PROTECTION

### Measures — Full Compliance of the Children's Act

**Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama on behalf of Mrs Mavis Nkansah-Boadu (NPP — Afigya Sekyere East):** Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection what measures the Ministry is taking to ensure the full compliance to Section 87 of the Children's Act 1998(Act 560), which prohibits Child Labour exploitation.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minister?

**Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection (Dr Agnes Naa Momo Lartey) (MP):** Thank you, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, child protection and labour issues are cross-cutting and need the attention of all relevant institutions to work together to address them. To the Ministry, child protection is concerned with human trafficking prevention, awareness creation on the prevention of violence against children and improving the legal and policy framework for the protection of children.

To ensure the implementation of Section 87 of the Children's Act of 1998 (Act 560), which prohibits child labour and exploitation, we have trained law enforcement officers, including the Judiciary, to understand the implications

of Section 87 on their work through the National Plan of Action for the Prevention of Child Labour. We have defined child labour in the simplest terms to guide their work. Through our partners, we have trained 570 law enforcement officers to identify, prevent and intercept child labour and human trafficking, as well as protect victims when rescued. This is to also improve investigations and prosecution of child labour and human trafficking offences. In the same way, we have also built the capacities of 138 judges from the circuit, district and magistrate courts since 2022 till date.

The Ministry has reviewed and launched the National Plan of Action for the Elimination of Human Trafficking for the period 2022 to 2026. So far, 2,500 copies of the National Plan of Action for the Elimination of Human Trafficking have been printed and disseminated to stakeholders working on the field. The plan is also on the Ministry's website and has 1,419 downloads.

7.53 p.m.

To ensure effectiveness of the plan, Standard Operating Procedures have been developed and simplified versions that are child friendly and easy to read have been printed and shared. The Ministry has consistently embarked on awareness-raising campaigns, community engagements and commemorated calendar day events, including the World Day against Trafficking in Persons and the World Day against Child Labour.

Awareness creation was undertaken through community dialogue and sensitisation, engagement with both in and out of school children on the dangers of child labour. More than 200,000 people have been sensitised nationwide. A grievance redress system is available to address child labour issues in the country, and anyone can call 0800800800 or 0800900900 for a response from the Ministry.

Mr Speaker, 794 victims were rescued in 2024, which was made of 505 adults and 289 children. The 289 children were made up of 105 girls and 184 boys rescued from child labour, trafficking and all other forms of exploitation. These child victims also received comprehensive trauma-informed care from the Government shelters and private shelters. In terms of investigations, a total number of 273 cases were reported for human trafficking to our law enforcement institutions.

Mr Speaker, 65 cases were sent to court and prosecuted, and 5 persons were convicted for child exploitation. We are also amending the Children's Act to better protect children from labour-related exploitation and ensure that better services for victims of child labour are improved.

Mr Speaker, before I conclude, let me state that issues of Child Labour are directly under the Child Labour Unit of the Labour Department under the Ministry of Labour, Jobs and Employment. We work together and serve on the technical committee

established to curb issues of Child Labour. Our unique collaboration has seen great strides as Ghana remains on a tier two ranking in this year's global trafficking in Persons Ranking Report due to the hard work undertaken by the Ministry. Through monitoring and evaluation, we hope to further strengthen policy and make new recommendations for policy areas that will ensure all stakeholders are following standards to protect children in Ghana.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much. Dr Mahama, I will give one supplementary question.

**Dr Mahama:** Mr Speaker, I want to find out from the Minister what institutional safeguards are in place to distinguish between child work and child labour. This is because there has been this particular confusion, which is affecting the reputation of Ghana in terms of the lack of differentiation between the two.

**Dr Lartey:** Mr Speaker, I think child labour is clearly defined, and it is defined as any exploitative or hazardous work that is harmful to the child's development and well-being. That is any work that affects the child's health negatively and compromises their education and protection. So, with all the stakeholders, not just the Ministry, when such cases come, we are able to sit and assess per the law because we cannot go beyond the law. We are able to see whether it is assessed or determined as child labour or exploitative work. Thank you.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** So, we will take the Question numbered 19.

**Dr Mahama:** Mr Speaker, again, I seek your leave to ask the question on behalf of the Hon Member. Do I have your permission?

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Yes, go ahead.

### **The Increasing Number of Streetism Among Children**

**Dr Abdul-Kabiru Mahama Tiah on behalf of (Mrs Mavis Nkansah-Boadu) (NPP —Afigya Sekyere East):** Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection, the plans of the Ministry to address the increasing number of streetism among children of school-going age.

**Dr Lartey:** Mr Speaker, the Ministry previously launched two initiatives dubbed "Operation Go Back to School" and "Operation Get Off the Streets for a Better Life" in 2015 and 2017, respectively. A total of 4,853 street persons were identified; out of this figure, 4,165 were eligible for formal education. Some 200 were reunited with their families and are in school. The exercise also identified 46 (20 adults and 26 children) Nigerian street beggars, and they were repatriated in 2017.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry has been persistent in dealing with the use of children for begging on the streets. On

13<sup>th</sup> April, 2022, the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection established an Inter-Ministerial Committee consisting of relevant Ministries. A technical committee was established and tasked to develop a plan to address the menace of street beggars.

The Embassy of Niger in collaboration with the Ghana Immigration Service (GIS), the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection and other relevant stakeholders repatriated 1,320 Nigeriens to their home country in June 2022.

Mr Speaker, a National Strategic Plan for Street-Connected Children in Ghana has been developed to ensure that street-connected children have access to essential services to become responsible citizens. The Plan was reviewed during the commemoration of the 2023 International Day for Street Children (IDSC).

The 2023 commemoration of the International Day for Street Children (IDSC) also led to the establishment of the Street Children Technical Committee. The mandate of the Committee is to improve coordination among stakeholders to achieve desirable results. The members of the Committee include the Department of Social Welfare, the Coalition of Non-Profit Organisations for street-connected children, United Nations International Children's Emergency Fund (UNICEF), and the Catholic Relief Services.

Mr Speaker, the situation has gone beyond social and is now a national

security issue. The Ministry of the Interior recently repatriated some street-connected people from our streets, and I urge us all to sustain the gains made.

Mr Speaker, the implementation of the decentralisation governance in Ghana mandates Metropolitan Municipal and District Assemblies (MMDAs) to protect children within their jurisdiction as enshrined in Section 16(1) of the Children's Act 1998 (Act 560). Mr Speaker, I quote:

“A District Assembly shall protect the welfare and promote the rights of children within its area of authority and shall ensure that within the district, governmental agencies liaise with each other in matters concerning children.”

8.03 p.m.

Mr Speaker, in this regard, we entreat all MMDAs to ensure children are prevented from using the street for begging and selling.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much.

Yes, Hon Member?

**Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko:** Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity.

Mr Speaker, I take it from the last statement of the Hon Minister with regard to entreating MMDAs to support the discourse of ensuring that children are prevented from being on the street.

The reality is that beyond Accra, all the other regional capitals or communities where we see children beg, it is predominantly Ghanaian children who are on the streets begging.

So, what are the pragmatic steps beyond this entreatment to the Ministries? Per the data that is available, are there any steps that the Ministry is taking to give us some targets to say that, if per our data, we have these number of children in our streets over these years? Does the Ministry have a plan that would ensure that we move all our children from the street and get them in the appropriate areas?

Mr Speaker, thank you very much

**Dr Lartey:** Mr Speaker, as I earlier mentioned, it is not just the mandate of the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection, but we are working with the other security agencies, and there is a task force that is working on that. In terms of a plan and a strategy, I will have to confer with them before I can put anything out there, especially when it is leaning, like I said, more towards security issues.

But I can assure Hon Members that there are pragmatic steps being taken, and it is not only on the streets of Accra; it is beyond Accra and every peculiar area or jurisdiction will have a different approach or strategy to ensure that the streets are safe and the children are well protected.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much.

Hon Member for Kwesimintim, do you want to say something?

Hon Members, on behalf of the House, let me thank the Hon Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection for attending before the House to answer Questions from her own Colleagues.

Hon Minister, we are grateful to you, and you are hereby discharged.

Yes, now let me take the Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources. Hon Minister, before that, let me thank you for patiently sitting through the proceedings. So, we will take the Urgent Question on page 2, and it is Question (c), from Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib, Member of Parliament for Weija-Gbawe.

Hon Member, you may take your Urgent Question now.

## URGENT QUESTIONS

### MINISTRY OF WORKS, HOUSING AND WATER RESOURCES

#### Measures to Avert Flooding in Weija-Gbawe

**Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib (NPP—Weija-Gbawe):** Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources, the measures the Ministry has implemented to avert the issue of flooding in Weija-Gbawe and Greater Accra to avoid loss of lives and property.

**Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources (Mr Kenneth Gilbert Adjei):** Mr Speaker, the concerns raised by the Hon Member are both valid and deeply aligned with the Ministry's ongoing priority to mitigate flooding, particularly in high-risk areas, such as the Kele and Wiaboman within the Weija-Gbawe Municipality.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry, through its implementing agency, the Ghana Hydrological Authority, has undertaken preliminary assessments in the Municipality. Key factors contributing to the persistent flooding include inadequate and heavily silted drainage infrastructure, encroachment on watercourses and floodplains, poor solid waste management, rapid and unregulated urban development.

Mr Speaker, to address these, the Ministry has initiated and implemented a following intervention:

1. Technical assessment, ongoing hydrological and hydraulic studies are being conducted to map up flood-prone zones and prioritise remedial actions.
2. Drainage proposals: A comprehensive drainage improvement plan is being finalised. It includes the construction and upgrading of culverts and stormwater channels.
3. Collaborative enforcement: In partnership with the Greater Accra Regional Coordinating Council. Efforts are underway to enhance land use regulation and to protect drainage channels from further encroachment.

4. Master plan integration: Weija-Gbawe has been incorporated into the Greater Accra Regional Drainage Master Plan currently under development.

Mr Speaker, in addition, the Ministry has already executed key projects in the Weija-Gbawe Municipality, including dredging the Densu River and Oblogo and Tetegu drains. Construction of storm drains at Gbawe Zero and Bale Mallam.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry remains committed to providing strategic direction and infrastructure to reduce the incident and impact of flooding, and we count on the continuous support of this House.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Shaib, any supplementary questions?

**Mr Shaib:** Mr Speaker, that is so, and this is just to commend the Minister, first of all, for all the steps he is taking. We are very minded and very assured that he would continue doing so.

It is also just to bring to his attention that we also have Korkorjor, which is a place that we are looking at, and then there is an estuary that connects to Kele, and also there is one that the Ministry did which they have not finished, which is around the Faith Montessori and C-Connie area, which is called Bale. That has a connection through the side of the Faith Montessori School to the beer depot behind the Gbawe Police Station, Blue Cross, to Pentecost Vocational, and also to Mallam—There is a place called Jerry Street, so if he would have that done, so that they fully finish.

But we want to take this opportunity to highly commend the Hon Minister. We are sure that he is doing so well to support us to finish. The one across Attala, I brought that to the attention of the Deputy Minister, and if we are able to do that as early as possible, I am sure it would help save lives and properties. So, please, this is just for his attention, not any further question.

Thank you very much.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much.

So, we turn to Question 79, which stands in the name of Mr Michael Kwesi Aidoo, Member for Oforikrom.

## ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

### MINISTRY OF WORKS, HOUSING AND WATER RESOURCES

#### **Action Taken on the Bomso- Oforikrom Link Road Bridge**

**Mr Michael Kwasi Aidoo (NPP — Oforikrom):** Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources what action is being taken on the Bomso-Oforikrom link road bridge which has stalled and when the Ministry will consider the construction of the storm drain at Anloga Junction linking Asawase

**Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources (Mr Kenneth Gilbert Adjei):** Mr Speaker, the Aboabo Stream is a significant drainage channel within the Oforikrom Municipality.

Ultimately, discharging to the River Sisan. Recognising the recurrent flooding challenges in the area, the Ministry of Works, Housing and Water Resources, through the National Flood Control Programme, initiated the Anloga culvert project to improve stormwater conveyance and mitigate flooding risks. This project was awarded in the 2020 National Flood Control Programme, with Ghana Hydrological Authority serving as the Ministry's Implementation Authority.

8.13p.m.

The Anloga Drainage Project involved the construction of a culvert and associated drainage infrastructure to mitigate flooding along the corridor. Construction commenced in 2022 and was successfully completed in 2024. The culvert is now fully operational and open to vehicular and pedestrian traffic.

Mr Speaker, concerning the Bomso-Oforikrom Link Road Bridge, which lies upstream of the Anloga Culvert, the Ministry wishes to clarify that this project was implemented by the Ghana Highway Authority; while construction of that bridge has been completed, it is yet to be officially open for public use. The Ministry is in active engagement with relevant stakeholders to ensure its commissioning and operationalisation.

Mr Speaker, with respect to stormwater management in the Anloga-Asawase area, the Ministry acknowledges the need for further assessments to determine additional appropriate drainage interventions. The Ministry, through the Ghana Hydrological Authority, will



engage relevant stakeholders to explore options to address any outstanding flood risk concerns.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry of Works, Housing and Water Resources remains committed to addressing drainage and flood control challenges in urban centres across the country and will continue to prioritise critical interventions to enhance resilience and infrastructure development.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Member, let me give you just one supplementary question. I hope you would bear with me.

**Mr Aidoo:** Mr Speaker, I will use the opportunity to urge the Minister to consider the Anloga-Asawase Drainage as an urgent intervention.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minister, did you hear his question? It was not a question. All right, you just commended him. Hon Minister, it appears you are doing well; all of them are commending you.

We will take the Question numbered 106 which stands in the name of the Hon Member of Parliament for Madina, Mr Francis-Xavier Kojo Sosu.

### **Measures to Modernise Madina Market**

**Mr Francis-Xavier Kojo Sosu (NDC — Madina):** Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources the measures being taken to modernise the Madina market

and to complete all outstanding drainage projects in the Madina Constituency.

**Mr Adjei:** Mr Speaker, the Ministry recognises the importance of the Madina Constituency in our national flood mitigation efforts. Accordingly, under the National Flood Control Programme, stormwater drainage projects were initiated in the municipality in 2018 and 2020 to reduce the incidence of flooding.

Mr Speaker, the Ghana Hydrological Authority has incorporated the continuation of the Madina drainage system in the Greater Accra Drainage Master Plan. Specifically, the Madina drains have been captured in the Public Investment Plan (PIP), under the Medium-Term Expenditure Framework (MTEF), for implementation of the remaining phases once approval is received from Ministry of Finance.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry remains committed to collaborating with all relevant agencies to modernise infrastructure and safeguard communities. We assure the Hon Member and this House of our resolve to protect lives and livelihoods in Madina and other vulnerable areas across the country.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Xavier, I will give you one opportunity to ask a supplementary question.

**Mr Sosu:** Mr Speaker, I also want to add my voice to earlier voices to commend the Hon Minister, particularly for the assurances given to the people of Madina in light of the recent floods. I am so grateful that he has assured us that,

once they have financial clearance, our drains within the municipality would be considered and prioritised.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Once again, Hon Minister, all of them are commending you.

We will now take the last Question which stands in the name of Hon Seth Osei-Akoto, Hon Member of Parliament for Atwima Mponua.

### **Resumption of Solar-Powered Water System Project at Tanodumase and Apenimadi**

**Mr Seth Osei-Akoto (NPP — Atwima Mponua):** Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources when works will resume on the abandoned community solar-powered water system at (i) Tanodumase and (ii) Apenimadi in the Atwima Mponua Constituency.

**Mr Adjei:** Mr Speaker, the Ministry of Works, Housing and Water Resources oversees two state institutions responsible for water supply in Ghana. The Ghana Water Limited is responsible for water supply services to urban areas, while the Community Water and Sanitation Agency (CWSA) is mandated to facilitate the provision of safe water and related sanitation services to rural communities and small towns in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, our records indicate that none of these two agencies under the Ministry initiated or implemented the

aforementioned solar-powered water system project at Tanodumase and Apenimadi. Therefore, we do not have any official information or update regarding the status or progress of the project.

Mr Speaker, it is important to acknowledge that interventions of this nature are, oftentimes, carried out by district assemblies, development partners, and NGOs or Community-based initiatives. We, therefore, respectfully recommend that the Hon Member of Parliament for the Atwima Mponua Constituency liaise with the management of Atwima Mponua District Assembly, who may have oversight regarding the mentioned infrastructure projects to obtain the necessary information on their implementation status or completion.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, any supplementary question?

**Mr Osei-Akoto:** Mr Speaker, I would like to thank the Hon Minister for providing the Answer.

Respectfully, for his information, I asked this Question based on the data we have from the district assembly and the urgency of water shortages in those communities. That was why I used this opportunity to ask him this Question.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Very well. So, does it mean you are satisfied with the Answer?

**Mr Osei-Akoto:** Yes, Mr Speaker.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** If I got the Answer right, it appears his Ministry is not responsible for that. Very well.

Hon Minister, let me thank you for sitting through the proceedings throughout the day and you have also responded to Members in all the Questions they have filed for you in a well-composed manner. We thank you, and you are hereby discharged.

Leader, are you in my hands?

**Mr Dafeamekpor:** Mr Speaker, entirely so.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** I had wanted to take one Statement but if—

**Mr Dafeamekpor:** Mr Speaker, I agree that we have some outstanding Statements, but we are entirely in your hands. So, if we can accommodate two, we will do that and they will be delivered without comments.

**Alhaji Habib Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, we are ready to do Business—*[Laughter]*—Mr Speaker, clearly, you could see that the Majority Leader and the Majority Chief Whip want us to adjourn; we do not want to adjourn. We still have Business to do, so let us continue with the Statements, but it should be one Statement, not two.

8.23 p.m.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, yesterday, I promised two

Members that I would take their Statements. In fact, they were supposed to be three but one of them has been taken. I will take the rest of the two, but there will be no comments. I will just ask them to read and it will go into the records. Is that all right with the owners of the Statements? If that is all right, then we will take it. If it is not, then we will take it tomorrow.

**Mr Dafeamekpor:** Mr Speaker, the other maker of the Statement, Hon Eric Afful has stepped out, so we will take that of my Brother.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** No, we will take his and that of Mr Samuel Awuku.

**Mr Dafeamekpor:** All right.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** So, my Brother, let us hear you.

## STATEMENTS

### World Day to Combat Desertification and Drought

**Mr Ebenezer Alumire Ndebilla (NDC — Zebilla):** Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to make this Statement, to mark the World Day to Combat Desertification and Drought observed annually on June 17 which was yesterday. It is a day that calls global attention to the urgent need to protect our land and safeguard our environment against degradation and water scarcity.

This year's commemoration is on the theme "Restore the Land, Unlock the

Opportunities”. This year’s theme emphasises the multiple benefits of land restoration, including improved livelihoods, increased food security, and a healthy planet. This is of particular relevance to Ghana, and more specifically to northern Ghana, where desertification, erratic rainfall, and prolonged droughts are not just environmental challenges, but daily realities threatening the livelihoods, food security, and the very survival of our people.

Mr Speaker, the northern savannah ecological zone, which includes my beloved constituency, Zebilla, and many others across the Upper East, Upper West, North East, Northern, and Savannah Regions, are among the most vulnerable areas in the country.

Mr Speaker, communities in these regions are experiencing rising temperatures, declining soil fertility, shrinking water bodies, and devastating bushfires, all worsened by climate change and unsustainable land use practices. The consequences are real; low crop yields, food insecurity, increased migration, and worsening poverty.

It is in this context, Mr Speaker that I wish to highlight the importance of the “Trees for Life” initiative launched under the visionary leadership of President John Dramani Mahama. This bold afforestation programme was not just a symbolic gesture, but a strategic national response to combat the twin threats of desertification and drought, especially in our vulnerable northern regions.

Mr Speaker, under this initiative, millions of tree seedlings, both economic and indigenous species were distributed and planted across the country, with special focus on degraded areas in Ghana. Communities, schools, faith-based groups, and local assemblies were mobilised to reclaim lost forest cover, promote climate resilience, and restore soil productivity. It was a grassroot movement with national significance.

What made the “Trees for Life” programme particularly effective, Mr Speaker, was its integration with local livelihoods. Communities were encouraged to plant economic trees such as shea, dawadawa, and mango, and cashew—Thereby linking environmental restoration with income generation. The initiative also employed thousands of youths under the Youth Employment Agency and Forestry Commission, offering both skills and jobs in forest regeneration.

Mr Speaker, we must acknowledge that although the initiative will undoubtedly make significant strides, deforestation and land degradation continue to threaten Northern Ghana. The annual loss of tree covers due to illegal logging, charcoal production, bushfires, and poor farming practices remained a threat and can reverse gains that the Tree for Life will bring. In addition, changing rainfall patterns have made traditional farming seasons increasingly unpredictable.

Therefore, I call on this House and the government to:

- a. Reinvigorate and upscale the “Trees for Life” initiative, making it a permanent pillar of Ghana’s climate adaptation strategy.
- b. Ensure sustainable funding for tree planting, watering, and protection, especially in the north where water access is a challenge.
- c. Expand public education on the dangers of desertification and the importance of indigenous tree species.
- d. Promote agroforestry and sustainable farming as key tools to combat land degradation.
- e. Enhance collaboration with traditional authorities and local assemblies to enforce bye-laws against indiscriminate tree felling and bush burning.

Mr Speaker, as we commemorate this important day, let us remember that the battle against desertification and drought is not one of science alone; it is one of survival and intergenerational justice.

We owe it to the farmers of Zebilla, the school children in Chereponi, the women shea collectors in Tumu in Sissala, and the future generations of Ghana to protect the land they depend on. Let us act boldly and urgently for indeed, when the last tree dies, the last man dies.

Thank you, Mr Speaker for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you, it is a very important Statement. So, Hon Samuel Awuku, you may also take yours.

### **Engagement with Deaf Students from Mampong School for the Deaf**

**Mr Samuel Awuku (NPP — Akuapem North):** Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make this Statement. I do so on the basis of insights gathered during a recent engagement between some Hon Members of Parliament and the students and staff of the Senior High Technical School for the Deaf in Mampong.

The forum, organised by the Department of Public Engagement and graciously supported by myself, MP for Akuapem North, was an important demonstration of Parliament’s commitment to inclusive dialogue and participatory democracy.

Mr Speaker, the encounter provided a platform for students living with hearing impairments to interact directly with legislators and provide them with a real world understanding of how Parliament works, including ways through which they can actively participate. The session, which featured presentations by several Hon Members, including Hon Fred Agbenyo, Hon Edem Agbana, Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah, Hon Shirley Kyei, and Hon Worlasi Kpeli was inspiring and enlightening in equal measure.

More importantly, it highlighted critical concerns and thoughtful proposals made

by the students and their teachers. These require Parliament's attention, inclusive responses, and in some cases, targeted deliberate intervention.

Mr Speaker, the first and most pressing issue raised by the students was the absence of a dedicated legislative framework for deaf education in Ghana. Currently, the only Senior High Technical School for the Deaf in the country functions without a law that secures its future through guaranteed funding, policy direction, and institutional support. This gap leaves the school vulnerable to inconsistent budgetary allocations, administrative neglect, and limited infrastructural development.

Such legislation, Mr Speaker, would do more than fund a school; it would serve as a national commitment to inclusivity, equity, and sustainable educational development for a marginalised group of our population, and this would be in accordance with the Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) 4 which targets quality education.

8.33 p.m.

Target 4.5 which aims to eliminate gender disparities in education and ensure equal access to all levels of education and vocational training for vulnerable groups, including people with disabilities, indigenous peoples, and children in vulnerable situations, by 2030.

Mr Speaker, the second matter of concern is infrastructure. The school currently operates from two physically separated campuses—North and South.

This setup forces students to cross busy roads several times a day, risking their lives just to access food or attend classes.

Furthermore, students depend on taxis to transport food between the campuses. This unreliable system has often resulted in delays, and in some cases, complete failure to deliver meals, thereby affecting student nutrition and concentration. An on-site dining hall is recommended to ensure nutrition and eliminate reliance on external logistics.

Mr Speaker, the recommendation for a centralised and accessible learning environment, complete with an on-site dining facility, must be taken up by the Ministry of Education with support from Parliament.

Mr Speaker, the third issue relates to the inadequacy of the current national curriculum in addressing the needs of deaf learners. Teachers explained that most lessons have to be repeated multiple times due to comprehension delays, and that current assessment structures do not account for the unique learning methods required by hearing-impaired students.

As such, the students proposed a comprehensive review of the National Curriculum for Deaf Learners to incorporate:

- Sign language-based instructional materials;
- Visual learning tools;
- Simplified content structures; and

- Extended teaching and assessment time.

Additionally, they recommended the recruitment and training of more sign language interpreters, the provision of learning aids, and specialised professional development for teachers in deaf education.

Mr Speaker, Parliament must take steps to ensure that inclusive education becomes a practical reality rather than a theoretical aspiration. We must empower and urge the Ghana Education Service (GES) to work with curriculum experts and disability advocates to revise content, pedagogy, and assessment methods.

Mr Speaker, another area of concern is the systemic exclusion of deaf individuals from Ghana's justice system. Deaf persons have encountered difficulties in attempting to report crimes, defend themselves, or pursue justice due to the absence of trained interpreters at police stations and in courtrooms.

This gap is a violation of basic human rights and goes against the country's pursuit of achieving Target 10.2 of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDG), Goal 10 (Reduced Inequalities) which aims to empower and promote the social, economic, and political inclusion of all people, regardless of age, sex, disability, race, ethnicity, origin, religion, or other status by 2030. Parliament must, therefore, clarify and enforce the responsibility of state institutions, especially the Ghana Police Service and the Judicial Service, to provide qualified sign language

interpreters during legal and investigative proceedings involving deaf individuals.

The students also highlighted the need for disability-sensitive civic and legal education. Many are unaware of their constitutional rights or the legal channels available to them.

Mr Speaker, Parliament must champion the development of civic education programs tailored to students with disabilities. These should be implemented through the National Commission for Civic Education (NCCE) and mainstreamed across the country.

Mr Speaker, one of the most progressive proposals made at the forum was for Parliament to formally recognise Ghanaian Sign Language as a national language. The students argued, quite rightly, that such recognition would affirm their identity, improve public understanding, and promote greater national cohesion as done in South Africa, Kenya, Uganda, Portugal, Paraguay among other countries. The UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (CRPD), Article 21 calls on states to recognise and promote the use of sign languages. This includes accepting and facilitating the use of sign languages, Braille, and other accessible means of communication in official interactions.

Parliament must explore legislative options and possibly constitutional amendments to recognise Ghanaian Sign Language, integrate it into the basic education system, and expand sign language training across public institutions.

Mr Speaker, the role of educators in deaf education cannot be overstated. Teachers at the Senior High Technical School for the Deaf provide not only academic instruction but emotional and psychological support to their students.

Yet, they do this under challenging conditions — without specialised allowances and often with inadequate accommodation. The students called for an "emotional allowance" for their teachers similar to that provided to village teachers. They also urged authorities to expand staff accommodation to boost morale and performance.

Parliament must give serious consideration to these recommendations. Incentivising and retaining skilled educators in special needs schools is essential to bridging the inclusion gap in our educational system.

Mr Speaker, in light of these concerns, Parliament has a vital role to play in transforming policy into practice. I respectfully propose the following interventions:

First, Parliament should refer this Statement and its recommendations to a joint sitting of the Committees on Education; Gender, Children and Social Protection; and Constitutional, Legal and Parliamentary Affairs.

Second, Parliament must advocate for the introduction of a Public Bill or Private Member Bill that provides for:

- a. Dedicated funding streams for deaf education;
- b. Clear national standards for curriculum, staffing, and infrastructure; and
- c. Legal obligations for inclusive service delivery across sectors.

Third, Parliament should exercise its oversight mandate to ensure that resources allocated under the District Assemblies Common Fund (DACF) for Persons with Disabilities are equitably distributed and directly benefit institutions like the Senior High Technical School for the Deaf, School for the blind and others.

Fourth, Parliament should urge the Ministry of Education to conduct an infrastructure audit of all special needs schools and submit a plan for campus upgrades and staff housing projects.

Fifth, a Motion should be introduced mandating all public legal and justice institutions to provide accessible legal services for the deaf, including sign language interpretation.

Finally, Parliament should request an annual report from the Ministry of Education on the status of special needs education in Ghana, with specific data on student enrolment, curriculum delivery, teacher retention, and infrastructure conditions.

Mr Speaker, the students of the Senior High Technical School for the



Deaf in Mampong are not asking for sympathy. They are asking for fairness and equity. They are not demanding special treatment. They are demanding equal opportunity.

Let us, as a House, respond to their call with urgency, empathy, and resolve. Let this House be remembered as the Parliament that listened not just with its ears, but with its conscience.

May this House be remembered as the House that moved beyond its comfort zone to put smiles on the faces of these deaf students.

8.43 p.m.

May the deliberations that follow, Mr Speaker, not just bring about real change for our students who spoke to these Hon Members of Parliament, but for all marginalised communities in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, on this note, I want to say thank you and thank you on behalf of these students from the Senior High School for the Deaf and for these blind students as well. Thank you. *[Hear! Hear!]*

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much, Hon Members. I am not taking any comments. I think I made it clear. The two Statements are very important Statements, but —

Two minutes.

**Mr Francis-Xavier Kojo Sosu (NDC— Madina):** Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, I want

to thank the makers of the Statements, particularly the second Statement, for such a very detailed Statement that borders on persons with disabilities generally, and more importantly, the persons who are having speech impairment.

Mr Speaker, it is so crucial because not only do we need policy directions to help persons who are deaf, but also persons with visual impairment. Mr Speaker, we would realise that the way we treat our vulnerable persons in this country leaves much more to be desired, and that is why I really associate myself to the Statement ably made by my Brother.

Mr Speaker, I would also join him to urge on the House that the Statement be referred to the various Ministries and actors that he has made reference to in the Statement.

Mr Speaker, finally I would want to also say that a society's development is determined by how they treat their most vulnerable persons. If we are going to determine the quality of life in Ghana, how Ghana is doing well, it will be judged by how we treat the most vulnerable. When one comes to Ghana, for example, one would think that even the churches should be at the forefront of protecting these vulnerable persons. But in Ghana, there is only one known church, Church of Christ, that has a deaf ministry. So sometimes I ask myself, so for all these big churches around, do they exclude persons who are deaf? Because when they are preaching, there are no sign languages, so it is quite difficult to really understand how these people are

integrated into our society. So Mr Speaker, I think this is a very important thing.

Mr Speaker, it is my prayer that you make the appropriate orders so we can follow up. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Were you here yesterday?

**Mr Sosu:** Mr Speaker, I was here yesterday.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** What did we say about referrals?

**Mr Sosu:** Very well, Mr Speaker, I defer to you.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** We will take that holistic decision.

So, on that note, let me thank the makers of the Statements and thank all of you for cooperating with me to stay up to this time. It is now 15 minutes to 9 p.m., so we have gone beyond the normal time. I thank you once again and I will go ahead to adjourn the House to tomorrow, 2 o'clock in the afternoon.

### ADJOURNMENT

*The House was adjourned at 8.48 p.m. till Thursday, 19<sup>th</sup> June, 2025 at 2.00 p.m.*

